Rake the Sands Until They Surface

Posted originally on the Archive of Our Own at http://archiveofourown.org/works/30739193.

Rating:
Mature

Archive Warning:
No Archive Warnings Apply

Category:
F/F

Fandom:
She-Ra and the Princesses of Power (2018)

Relationships:
Catra & Glimmer (She-Ra), Catra/Glimmer (She-Ra), Glimmer & Micah (She-Ra), Catra & Micah (She-Ra), Catra & Glimmer & Micah (She-Ra), Adora/Catra (She-Ra), Bow/Glimmer (She-Ra), Adora/Catra/Glimmer (She-Ra)

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Post-Canon, Angst, Platonic Kissing, Unresolved Sexual Tension, Family, Found Family, Magic, POV Alternating, POV Catra (She-Ra), POV Glimmer (She-Ra), Grief/Mourning, Childhood Trauma, Illustrations, Shotgun Wedding, Ghosts, Minor Adora/Glimmer (She-Ra), supernatural horror, Dark Magic, Magic School, dark academia i guess but it’s just because they’re at a school and there’s a haunting, Mystacor (She-Ra), mystacor is the school i mean

Language:
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Part 3 of She-Ra: The Magical Universe

Collections:
She-Ra Big Bang 2021

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Rake the Sands Until They Surface

by strongcat

Summary

It's been a year since the war ended and Etheria was freed from Horde Prime, and all should be well. But all is not well with Queen Glimmer, her father King Micah, and her friend—and foreign minister—Catra. In addition to their relationship being strained by grief, Glimmer and Micah find themselves suddenly unable to cast spells. Meanwhile, Glimmer and Catra have to address the uncomfortable facts of their friendship: what happened to Queen Angella, and who was responsible. Between all of them, a shadow still hangs. Can a trip to Mystacor solve all their problems, or will the past always haunt them?

—

Featuring illustrations by EmileeDoodles.

Notes

fic playlist (it’s on apple music im so sorry)

See the end of the work for more notes

prologue

Chapter Notes

content warning in this chapter for slightly graphic violence, blood, and death.

"Ghosts of my childhood, stay with me if you will / Find a place where there's water, hold you under 'til you still"

- The Mountain Goats, "Outer Scorpion Squadron"

On the first day of the second autumn since the end of the war, **Queen Glimmer** woke up to drops of rain on the window. Gray, pre-dawn light coaxed her eyes open little by little, glinting off the crystal lamps hanging from her tall ceiling. She shifted around and got a face full of Bow's armpit hair. Wrinkling her nose, she carefully extracted herself from under her boyfriend's arm to look at the clock on their bed stand: too early to rush out of bed, but too late to go back to sleep, or she'd risk being late to her first meeting.

Usually Glimmer wouldn't have hesitated to wake Bow up—first with a gentle kiss, then some tickles, then maybe something else. But he had been out late the night before coming back from a construction site in Galebreath, so today, she let him sleep.

She pulled herself up, stretching and stifling a yawn as she eased her body back into wakefulness. She slid into her fluffy purple slippers, then paced gently toward the tea nook next to her desk. She drew a quick heat sigil to boil some water—but no glowing runes followed where her fingers traced.

The queen let her eyes fall closed and exhaled deeply. Her spells hadn't been working for a few days, and she still wasn't used to it. Her instincts still told her to *just cast a little spell* at nearly every opportunity (it was good practice, according to Micah and Aunt

Casta) and not being able to do so was impossibly frustrating, like trying to walk through a convenient doorway that had been bricked over for no discernible reason. She didn't have the patience to try again this morning. Instead, she reached for the electric hot plate that Bow kept in a drawer under the desk.

The ornate antique tea box was stocked with silk sachets of myriad flavors, herbal and caffeinated. Definitely something caffeinated this morning, Glimmer thought. Her hand paused over darjeeling as she remembered the first time she had tasted it. Her mother had told her the myth of how the Great Goddess Etheria had created the tea, but had deemed it too good for mortals and hidden it among the frozen mountains—until the angels of the moons had conspired to steal it and give it to the inhabitants of the Whispering Woods, for which they had been cast out. *"And now here we are,"* Angella had said, *"still drinking the same tea that got my foremothers in trouble in the first place."*

It was bitter—the tea, sure, but the memory now, too. Every time Glimmer thought of her mother was another minute spent steeping in nostalgia, then regret, then resentment, then guilt. She was starting to wonder if her memories could ever be sweet again.

Glimmer passed up the darjeeling in favor of a stronger, blacker blend from Mystacor. She was too tired for anything else.

Blood-red electricity crackled across **Catra** 's skin, all her muscles spasming and her joints locking into a painful hold. Shadows swirled around her and congealed into a form she couldn't see, but knew she would recognize if only she could turn around.

A seething voice whispered in her ear: *"Look at what you're doing, child. The only thing you've ever been good at is destroying, shredding, ruining. You're nothing but a beast set loose to wreak havoc on all that I've worked for."*

Before Catra's eyes—clouded with tears—stood another Catra, a few years younger with longer, wilder hair. She held a stun baton, scowling as she drove it into the back of her best friend. Then she turned around and the baton was a sword, which she threw down the wide chasm at her feet, saying, *"I really am going to miss you."*

Then she was sticking another baton into Entrapta's back, turning it on Scorpia, threatening her with a wild look on her face. Then that baton turned into a lever, and Catra took her younger self's place as she scowled and pulled it, breaking the world.

And then came the part Catra didn't expect. Instead of another one of her many very real mistakes, she saw an entirely unfamiliar scene. Well, not entirely unfamiliar—it was a hallway in Bright Moon, probably somewhere near the royal archives, she guessed. Adora ran toward her with open arms, but Catra didn't receive her embrace. What she did do was hold one hand straight out, claws bared, and dig into the tender spot right below Adora's ribcage, that little divot Catra liked to kiss sometimes. Her claws sank in and she couldn't stop herself. She thrusted upward and watched as blood dripped from the corner of Adora's mouth, open wide with shock and betrayal. Catra tried to scream, but what came out was a laugh. She pulled her claws out of Adora's flesh and her best friend, the love of her life, dropped to the floor dead.

Then Catra was turning around—not out of her own volition, but not by the nerve-grip of dark magic either. She was met with a tall figure in an old, red robe. Looking up, where she had expected to find a white-eyed mask, she saw the old witch's true face, the one Catra had only seen twice in her life, with pale green skin, scars and keloids and shattered pupils. That's what it was at first. But the longer she looked at it, the more it took on a different shape. Its ears grew longer, its skin paler. Its eyes changed color and shape—poison green, three on one side and one on the other.

A clawed hand gripped her throat and lifted with inhuman strength. As her vision went black around the edges, the last words she heard were these:

"Some creatures are destined only for destruction."

And then, she fell.

Catra jolted awake with the force of a body hitting the ground. Immediately, she sat up, looked around, and found Adora still sleeping peacefully next to her. She took stock of her surroundings otherwise: a trickling waterfall, a purple canopy, a confused, housecat-sized Melog blinking blearily at her from the foot of the bed.

The spectral cat mewed at her. Their voice echoed in her head with a question: *Nightmares?*

Catra nodded wordlessly, not wanting to risk waking Adora—though she wouldn't have minded some comfort right then, honestly. She looked her girlfriend over again, focused her hearing on the slow pulse in Adora's neck, the tide of her breathing. She was alive. That was enough for Catra. And she looked so damn cute sleeping like this, her wheat hair all splayed out like it didn't even know the word *ponytail,* her mouth hanging open slightly. She was drooling. Catra shouldn't have found that cute, but for some reason she did.

So, Catra pulled herself out of bed slowly, careful not to disturb the mattress too much, then slipped on some sweatpants and a t-shirt from the pile of not-dirty-but-definitely-not-clean clothes on the floor. Sensing her intent, Melog was already at the door, ready to get lost in Castle Bright Moon's corridors with her until the light of the first moon signaled the end of the long autumn night.

three meetings

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

"So," Micah said a little awkwardly between bites of cruller, "how are things with Bow?"

Glimmer shrugged as she dipped her own cruller into a hot bowl of chicken jook. She watched from behind heavy eyelids as the rice porridge slowly regained its shape.

"They're good," she said finally. "Still a little weird sometimes, but … good, mostly."

Micah hummed in approval. "You know," he started cautiously—Glimmer's eyes flicked up to meet his, "Casta told me how much Angie … how much *your mother* liked him, when he first started coming around."

The sadness in her father's gaze became too much, so she looked back down at her porridge and nodded silently.

"If she could see you now," said Micah, a tentative, watery smile in his voice, "I'm sure she'd be just as proud as I am."

"Well, she can't," Glimmer said, biting the words out under her breath. She glanced up at her father only briefly to see that awful, heartbroken look, the one he got whenever he tried to bond with Glimmer and found her too closed off, too broken. She averted her eyes toward a sparkling white pillar along the grand hall.

There was a long, mournful silence as father and daughter ate their breakfasts, together but separated. Then Glimmer felt a warm hand on top of hers. She looked at Micah hesitantly.

"You know it's okay to miss her," he said, slow and careful like he was addressing a child, "right?"

Glimmer pulled her hand away. Curtly, she replied, "I know, Dad."

And she did, really. It was *okay* to miss her mother. But was it useful? It wasn't helping her rebuild Bright Moon's cities and towns, revive its farmlands, reestablish trade. Wishing she had Angella's help wasn't making it easier to rehabilitate and repatriate thousands of Horde soldiers. Letting herself grieve didn't make it feel any better to be reminded each and every day of what she had lost.

Micah examined her expression, presumably looking for something he could salvage from this conversation: some fatherly advice he could give, something he could learn about his daughter, anything that would bring him closer to her. He settled on a change of subject:

"Is your spellcasting still acting up?" he asked, a slight lift in his voice despite the nature of the question. How sweet, Glimmer thought, that he still thought solving this problem together could bridge the divide between them.

Glimmer nodded anyway, and Micah continued, "Mine too. I'm going to get in touch with Casta to see if she might be able to help us." He smiled conspiratorially. "How's about a trip to Mystacor with your old man?"

"Sure," Glimmer grunted, looking down at her breakfast again, "whatever."

Had she been honest, she might have told her father that while an officially sanctioned vacation would be nice for her, it was dead last on the list of things she needed to do—things *her people* needed her to do. Right down there next to mourning her mother and mending her personal relationships.

Micah sighed. "Have you talked to Catra yet? I really think it might help you sort out some of this … stuff."

Glimmer's hands tightened into fists.

“There’s nothing to talk to her about, Dad,” the queen growled. “It’s just me.”

She drew a deep breath, released it, and closed her eyes.

“I’m fine.”

Queen Glimmer of Bright Moon was just not having it today.

They sat in the council room across from two old coots from Etheria’s swampy buttcrack who had each decided it was time for their respective kingdoms to reestablish relations with Bright Moon, which was awfully convenient, seeing as there was no longer a war to be fought. **Catra** had gotten a bad vibe from both of them as soon as they had walked in. One was dressed in a snooty, high-collared uniform with a big sash across his chest, the other in a floor-length gown with a smart little cap on his head. Each sported a graying mustache barely concealing a scowl directed at the other.

“Your Majesty, with all due respect,” the one in the cap said, “Bluestone has a very long history with Bright Moon, much longer than our … *esteemed* colleagues in Blackmore. We simply wish to have that history acknowledged as Your Majesty so wisely chooses how to distribute the surplus aid.”

The one in the sash huffed loudly at this, ruffling the wiry hairs of his mustache, all of which seemed to have migrated from the top of his head.

“Ridiculous. Your Majesty, this pompous fool has no idea what he’s talking about. Blackmore has always been a close ally of Bright Moon. Just because our relationship has not been *formal* in some time does not erase that.”

The queen leaned with both elbows on the table, steepling her fingers and sighing audibly at every exchange between the two diplomats. On her father’s advice, she was dressed conservatively

for this meeting—a simple, modest, electric purple dress, covered in glitter. The dark circles under her eyes completed the look.

Glimmer took a minute, adjusted her tiara, then leaned back in her chair to address her guests.

"Why are you asking for this additional aid, exactly? Either of you?"

Both men began bumbling and talking over each other as they looked for good excuses, but Catra saw right through both of them.

"To be frank, gentlemen," said Catra, tugging her jacket lapels and putting on her best Foreign Minister Voice, "I hadn't even heard of either of your kingdoms until you called to schedule this meeting. You weren't anywhere near the frontlines during the war, and you certainly weren't important enough for the Horde to take notice otherwise. If I had to guess, Your Majesty," she turned to Glimmer, but watched the two mens' reactions carefully out of the corner of her eye, "I'd say these two are just trying to get Bright Moon involved in their little … dick-measuring contest."

Glimmer just barely suppressed a snicker behind her hand. King Micah, seated on the other side of the queen, dropped his jaw and looked at Catra incredulously, but definitely didn't scold her. Meanwhile, the representatives from Blackmore and Bluestone sputtered indignantly.

Eventually, one of them managed, "I'd never have guessed that Bright Moon, once the most esteemed kingdom in all Etheria, could so easily lose its sense of decorum!"

"Apologies for the minister," Glimmer said, though she still smiled childishly and totally didn't mean it, "but she does have a point. There's no reason for either of you to be entitled to more aid than any other kingdom."

"This is disgraceful," grumbled the one with the sash. Then, under his breath, "Queen Angella would never have disregarded us like

this.”

All three of them, Catra, Glimmer, and Micah, stopped breathing at once. The representative from Blackmore’s eyes went wide as he realized his error.

“Please,” the diplomat begged, “I meant no offense, I simply—”

“It’s alright,” Micah interrupted politely. “Just a bit of a sore subject.”

But by the look on Glimmer’s face, it felt to Catra less like a sore subject and more like an open, bleeding wound. Glimmer closed her eyes, breathed a shaky breath, then stood up and spoke in a dire tone.

“Angella,” said the young queen, “is not here. You’re stuck with me. Better get used to it.”

Glimmer shot a sidelong glare at Catra, then disappeared in a shower of sparkles, leaving Catra and Micah staring at an empty seat. They made brief eye contact, and in that moment there was an invitation.

Although she had been working close to him for a while, Catra still hadn’t gotten used to the king’s presence. He was always there, sitting next to Glimmer, offering sage advice. But every so often he would try to reach out to Catra alone for reasons she couldn’t place. It made her feel like she was doing something wrong.

Micah’s brows furrowed, the corners of his mouth turning down slightly as he silently acknowledged the tension still left between his daughter and Catra. She grimaced with shame at his insightfulness. There was a sour feeling in her stomach that had been there ever since Glimmer showed up that morning, dead tired and with patience so thin you could see right through it into the bubbling anger underneath. Catra had a hunch that sourness wasn’t going away any time soon.

Cautiously, Micah turned back to the two diplomats.

“Let’s take a break for lunch, shall we, gentlemen? I’ll have the kitchen make your choice.” The king looked back at Catra with some resignation, some understanding that this will take a little more than an olive branch to solve.

Catra stood up, straightened her shirt, and prepared herself to face whatever she had coming.

The gardens within Castle Bright Moon’s battlements were vast and labyrinthine. Courtiers, diplomats, and the other princesses tended not to go near them. There were even superstitions among the people in Bright Moon Town and the outlying farmlands: bad luck, curses, ghost stories told by those who had explored the gardens after dark once, on a dare.

Catra didn’t believe in ghost stories. She didn’t. She only avoided the greenhouse near the entrance because there was nothing interesting about it—just a little glass hut with some strange-looking plants in it, long abandoned. The rest of the gardens, though, she would happily get lost in just to clear her head once in a while. That night after Glimmer had stormed out of the meeting was once in a while.

At the center of the hedge maze, there was a circular clearing with an elegant fountain in its center. It wasn’t something Catra had appreciated in the early days after the war—the idea of water being used for decoration had taken some getting used to—but now it was sort of pretty. The sound of it could be calming, as long as she didn’t look at the plaque affixed to its base, or the long-haired, winged statue standing atop its highest tier.

But of course, today Catra was forced to look at the statue of the departed Queen Angella—because the late monarch’s daughter was there, too.

Catra stopped in her tracks when she entered the clearing and saw Glimmer staring up at her mother’s likeness with the same unreadable look in her eyes she’d had all day. That sour feeling in

Catra's gut was back in full force, and she could put a name to it easily: guilt.

It had been almost a year since the end of the war. Seasons had changed. Kingdoms had been rebuilt. Peace had been made on all fronts—except this one. Catra and Glimmer had still not talked about what had happened to Angella. About the portal. And quite honestly, Catra was sick of it. She was sick of carrying this awful guilt around with her like a suitcase full of lead and not knowing where Glimmer wanted her to put it down, if at all. Every time it got close to being brought up, the queen would find an excuse to change the subject, or remember something she had to do, or just straight up disappear with no explanation. There was something awful hiding inside her, and whatever it was, Catra deserved to bear the brunt of it.

So, she decided, they were going to talk about it now. Or at least Catra would, and then Glimmer could do whatever the fuck.

Arms crossed over her chest, tail curled around her own leg, Catra approached the queen slowly.

"Hey, Sparkles."

Glimmer barely acknowledged her. She didn't turn her head, just stood as still as a statue and flicked her eyes—sparkling lavender under the moons and stars—toward Catra and then back again.

Grounding herself in the feeling of the grass under her feet, Catra began.

"Glimmer, listen … I know sometimes it's hard to be around me. And I just wanted to say, if you're still angry at me for…" Catra swallowed, and her voice came out even thinner than it had already been, "for what happened, I understand. And I'm sorry. If I could go back and take her place, or just stop the whole thing, I would, in a heartbeat. You…" and here was the part she didn't like to say out loud, the part that made a younger version of herself hiss and scratch, "You deserve so much better than what you got."

You deserve to have her. You got me instead.

For a few tense moments, Glimmer didn't react. She just kept watching the statue of her mother, maybe hoping it would come to life and tell her what to do. Then—

"It's okay."

"What?" Catra couldn't help the disbelief in her voice. "What do you mean it's okay? How … I killed your mom. How is that okay?"

At this, Glimmer turned away as if she had been slapped, obscuring her profile.

"You don't have to remind me."

The queen looked down at the grass, turned pale by the night-moons' glow, then at the plaque on the fountain. A single, twinkling tear formed in the corner of her eye.

"So what," said Catra, beginning to lose her patience, "are we just never going to talk about this?"

Finally, Glimmer looked at her straight on.

"Yeah, maybe," said the queen with surprising finality.

Catra pushed back. "But … you're supposed to hate me."

"I don't want to."

"Why?" The guilt in Catra's stomach flared up into a wildfire; her words came out like tongues of flame as she stepped closer. "Why are you holding back? I deserve it, Glimmer. I can take it. Let it out!"

Glimmer's tiny eyebrows furrowed, and her chin pushed up in that stupid little pout she always did, but she closed her eyes and took a deep breath. Her voice was startlingly clear when she spoke again.

“You really want me to let it out?”

The fire went out. Suddenly, the night air was so cold that Catra froze where she stood.

“Yes,” Catra said on a shaky breath.

Then, Glimmer was walking towards her and the tears in her eyes began spilling out.

“Well I can’t. I can’t hate you. You wanna know why?” said the queen, pointing a finger at Catra’s chest. “Because I already let it out, and it cost everyone too much. I drove my friends away so I could beat you, and it worked.”

Catra opened her mouth to defend herself, but Glimmer didn’t stop her assault.

“I handed you your ass. Don’t deny it. And then I brought Etheria to Horde Prime, and he took me, and he took *you,* and then you saved me. I made it out. But you didn’t. He tortured you, and violated you, and—and you *died.* You were fucking dead, Catra. I looked at your literal dead body lying on the floor in front of me and I decided I could never be mad at you again.”

The inexorable memories all came flooding back at once, and so did the anger and the guilt and the—

“But none of that would have happened,” Catra’s mouth said, unbidden, “if I hadn’t pulled the switch. Angella would still be here, the signal wouldn’t have gotten through, Horde Prime wouldn’t have found us.”

“And that means you deserved what he did to you? Look at me, Catra.” It was all she could do to obey and meet Glimmer’s burning gaze. “Look at me and tell me you deserved that.”

“I—” Catra cut herself off, but she nearly said it. Because really, if she searched what she knew about herself, her old self, she *had* deserved it.

Glimmer held back a frustrated scream behind her teeth. Her fists tightened as she turned around for a moment, then she spun back around—and her hands were on Catra's face and her *lips* were on Catra's lips and she was *kissing* her, so full of anger and grief that it burned. Catra froze for a second, but found herself parting her lips and letting the burn inside, letting it melt her, boil her, turn her into steam so she could float away, finally. Her hands drifted up to Glimmer's hips and stayed there as her fingers traced soft curves through the thin fabric of her dress. When her fang caught Glimmer's bottom lip, the queen let out a whimper into Catra's mouth that was frankly embarrassing, and she was *totally* telling Adora—

 Glimmer holding Catra's face, surging forward and kissing her

Wait.

Catra only did this with Adora. Adora was Catra's girlfriend. Catra loved Adora. Why was she doing this? And wait, didn't Glimmer only do this with Bow? Didn't Catra tease her every day about the fact that she was a half-celestial queen and she had a *boyfriend?* This had to be illegal.

But before Catra could wonder what the punishment was for making out with someone else's girlfriend, Glimmer pulled away. They stared at each other, both stunned into silence and stillness. The queen daintily wiped her mouth with the back of her hand, then faced away from Catra and straightened her posture.

"Don't read too much into that," said Glimmer hurriedly, and then in a flash of irritating pink sparkles, she was gone.

Chapter End Notes

> Before you freak out, I will NOT be breaking up Catradora or Glimbow, nor will this fic try to make the Best Friends Polycule happen.

ripples

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

"On the mouth?!"

"Yes, Adora, on the fucking mouth!" Catra snapped. She crossed her arms, sighed, then, "Sorry. I didn't mean to yell. I just feel … weird."

"Oh, it's okay," said Adora, a little too perky. "It's no big deal, it's just…"

Catra turned from where she had been pacing the bedroom to examine her girlfriend, who looked too attentive for this to be *no big deal.* "What?"

Adora blushed crimson, from her cheeks all the way down her long, elegant neck to her sternum and beyond. She let her loose hair fall in front of her face, still dark and wet from the shower.

"It's just … well," Adora started, then steeled herself with a deep breath before continuing, "did you like it?"

"Adora!" Catra shrieked as heat rushed into her face. For good measure, her tail puffed out too. If there had been any hope left of this conversation not being totally fucking weird, it had flown out the ridiculously ornamented window. "What kind of question is that?!"

"Just, you know—was she…" Adora made a gesture with her arms which did not seem to have anything to do with what she was saying. "Was she better than me?"

"Adora!"

"Sorry, sorry," she mumbled, then mimed zipping her mouth shut.

Catra began pacing again, stopping to idly examine some of the old maps Adora had pinned to their wall. On a map of Etheria's eastern continent, she noted that the kingdoms of Blackmore and Bluestone had been mislabeled for each other. She rolled her eyes and shook her head, trying to get the events of the day to fall neatly into line, like stacking mismatched books on a shelf.

"I don't even know what happened, honestly," Catra muttered half to herself. "It felt like Glimmer just kind of broke. Like she was holding all this stuff in, and I guess, you know … she started to let it out and stuff just … happened."

"Yeah," Adora chuckled, "I know how she gets sometimes."

Fear—shameful and quiet—gripped Catra's throat for a moment, making her voice tremble when she asked, "Did Glimmer ever kiss you?"

She watched out of the corner of her eye as Adora blushed again, and the jealousy took hold briefly before Adora said shyly, "No."

There was a question on the tip of Catra's lips, but Adora answered it before she could say anything.

"She definitely, uh … tried to, once. Before Princess Prom. She was freaking out because Bow was going as Perfuma's date, and I guess…" she tapered off, then looked at Catra with some kind of clarity in her eyes. "Losing people—or the fear of losing people—isn't something she handles well, is it?"

Catra shrugged. "Do any of us?"

"I guess not," Adora said, her face falling a little. "She's just always had this kind of sadness about her, as long as I've known her. Like something has always been missing, you know?"

Catra paced back towards the bed as she thought. To her, at first blush, Glimmer had seemed like the type who always got everything she wanted—just like Adora, she had thought bitterly. But as she'd gotten to know the queen, to work with her, be her

friend, she noticed more and more that Glimmer's way of life—the annoyingly chipper attitudes, the reckless optimism, the sparkles, it was all in *spite* of something. Or sometimes actually spite *ful.* For not the first time, Catra thought she herself might have more in common with Glimmer than Adora ever had.

"Yeah," she said simply, finding a seat next to Adora on the bed and resting her head in her hands, "I think I know."

They were both silent for a moment, but it wasn't the usual, comfortable silence Catra was used to. It was tense. Adora's leg bounced rapidly, which shook the mattress and disturbed Catra's swirling thoughts.

"I can feel you worrying," Catra accused, not quite teasingly. She lifted her head again and looked at her girlfriend with a quirked eyebrow. Adora was examining the middle distance like it was the most interesting thing on Etheria and worrying her bottom lip between her teeth. Catra put a hand on her shoulder and shook gently. "Adora."

"Hm?" she said, utterly failing to sound unbothered.

Slowly, like she had once spoken to her in childhood, Catra prompted, "What is it?"

"Oh, psh, it's…" Adora stood up and began pacing just as Catra had. She waved a hand dismissively while the other arm wrapped around her midsection. "It's nothing."

Catra gave her the *you're-a-terrible-liar* face, an unamused lift of the eyebrows and half a knowing smirk. Adora blushed again.

"Just—" Adora started, then held her hands in front of her like she was gripping a ball made of her own nerves. "Was she better than me, or not?"

"You *really* want to know if Glimmer is a better kisser than you?" Catra drawled, definitely teasing this time.

“Well, if you’re going to kiss other girls,” Adora explained seriously, “I feel like I at least have a right to know what I’m up against!”

Catra gave Adora that open, vulnerable look that she knew cut through all the red tape around her girlfriend’s heart, then pushed all the sarcasm out of her voice as she asked, “Adora, are you feeling jealous?”

Adora scoffed and turned to the side to avoid looking at Catra. “No, I’m not jealous, I just…”

“Adora,” Catra commanded calmly. Adora’s bright eyes, quickly darkening, went to her right away. She stood up and walked slowly over to Adora, taking both her hands in her own. She spoke quietly. “It’s okay to be jealous. I understand. It won’t happen again.”

Love relieved the expression on Adora’s face, which Catra took as a sign to continue.

“In fact,” she whispered, her tail snaking posessively around Adora’s waist as she pulled her closer, “I think it’s kind of hot that you’re jealous.”

“Oh,” Adora breathed heavily.

“Kind of makes me wonder…” Catra let her hands travel to Adora’s hips, “what you would do…” she leaned into Adora’s neck and purred, “to show everyone that I’m yours.”

“Oh,” Adora said again, and this time her voice sounded deep and raspy and a little bit wrecked. One calloused hand found its way up Catra’s back and into her ponytail, then tugged gently. Catra whimpered.

“In that case,” said Adora darkly, and oh, Catra *liked* this Adora, “yes, I’m jealous.” She pressed a slow, hot kiss to Catra’s jaw, then leaned further down and breathed hard against Catra’s neck. “Very, very jealous. Absolutely green with…” she nipped lightly at Catra’s pulse point, “jealousy.”

There was no further discussion of the issue that night.

"So, let me get this straight," Bow said, hands on his hips as he stood in front of Glimmer at the bay window. "You two were having a fight—"

"Something like that, yes," Glimmer interjected from behind her knees. She was curled up, surrounded by cushions and blankets, yet still felt totally exposed.

"And then you … kissed her?" He paused, and Glimmer nodded. "On the lips?"

"Yes, Bow, on the fucking lips!" she snapped, barely holding back tears of embarrassment. She looked up at Bow, and he just seemed worried for her, which almost made it worse. Her voice shrank as she continued, almost whimpering, "I'm sorry. I didn't think it would be that big of a deal. I mean, I've kissed her on the cheek before, and that was fine. I didn't expect it to be so … intense."

"Glimmer," Bow said, in that tone of voice he used when he did his *friendship guy* bit, "you have to know that kissing someone else on the lips is a way bigger deal than kissing them on the cheek. Have you been thinking about doing that for a long time?"

Heat rushed into Glimmer's cheeks under Bow's knowing gaze, his building frustration concealed by unwavering compassion. She tried several times to open her mouth and explain, but all that came out was a series of strained "uh" sounds.

Bow crouched down to level his eyes with Glimmer's. He smiled softly, placing firm, grounding hands on her shoulders.

"Hey," Bow said gently, "it's okay." He paused to rub some circles into her shoulders. "I know you think Catra's hot, you're not good at hiding it."

Glimmer hid behind her hands and groaned, almost sweating from the warmth behind her face.

"Just tell me, have you been wanting to kiss her like this for a long time?"

"No!" she whisper-yelled as she let her hands fall to her lap. "It just … happened. I got frustrated because she thought I didn't want her around and kept telling me I should hate her and I just couldn't take it anymore. I…" she tapered off, looked down at her clenched fists, then back up at Bow. He was looking at her the same way he always had—like he saw all of her at once, understanding and loving every part. His dark eyes brought her guard down gently. "She's a really good friend, Bow. A best friend, just as much as Adora, or even you. I guess I was just trying to show her that I want her around. I'm sorry it got out of hand."

Bow brought his warm hands to Glimmer's cheeks and pulled her into his kiss, ever gentle. His lips were pillow-soft and tasted like the same toothpaste he had been using since he was a kid. He pulled back, leaned his forehead against hers, looked at her in that same earnest way and said, "I forgive you."

Glimmer's whole body sighed with relief.

"You two definitely need to have a talk, though," he said more frankly. "Just work it out and move past it. It doesn't have to be weird."

"Okay," Glimmer said on an exhale, "I can do that."

"And for the record," Bow continued with that lecturing tone again, "I am okay if it turns out you want to kiss her again. You just have to talk to me about it first."

Glimmer shrieked indignantly, "It wasn't premeditated!"

They were lying in bed together that night, Glimmer reading the latest *Mer-Mysteries* novel with heavy eyes, Bow almost snoozing

with his head pillowed on her thighs. She finished another chapter, dog-eared the page, and set it down on her nightstand. Bow yawned against the skin of her thigh. He looked so cute when he was sleepy, a slight blush darkening his cheeks, his long eyelashes occasionally fluttering—she didn't dare disturb him. But she did still have to turn the lights off.

This wouldn't have been a problem, normally. Distant object manipulation wasn't particularly difficult for a sorcerer of her level, especially not when it was something as simple as flicking a switch from across a room. But with the problems she had been having lately, she couldn't afford to take any little enchantment for granted.

Glimmer closed her eyes and quieted her mind, focusing solely on the lightswitch on the wall by the door: how it was then, and how she wanted it to be. She took a deep breath, then reached her hand out into the field of magic around her—Etheria's life force. It had been warm and effervescent ever since the restraints of the Heart had been broken, compared to the quiet stillness of before, like a great, boiling hot spring had bubbled up through a pool of stagnant water.

Slowly, purposefully, Glimmer lifted a finger and imagined herself touching that metaphysical pool, tracing a small circle in the air through which she could reach the lightswitch. But as she completed the circle, she didn't feel the ripples it should have left. There was no simmering energy, no warmth, nothing. She opened her eyes and looked: there wasn't even the faintest glow of a spell circle hanging in the air.

Glimmer dropped her hand and groaned. It narrowly missed smacking Bow in the face, but he woke up anyway. He hummed creakily as his eyes fluttered open.

"Whas wrong?" Bow said, slurring and hoarse from stolen sleep.

Glimmer sighed. "My *fucking* spells still aren't *fucking* working. Even when I go totally by the book."

Bow pushed himself up and Glimmer whined at the loss of contact, but was quickly consoled as he pulled her in to snuggle against his side.

"And you're sure it's not a weird Moonstone thing?"

"Yeah, I'm sure," Glimmer said into Bow's armpit. "Since it's happening to Mi—to *Dad* too. Whatever it is, it's affecting both of us. We're going to Mystacor next week to see if Aunt Casta or anyone else knows what's going on."

Bow hummed in thought. "Why isn't Casta coming here instead? Isn't she here like three months out of the year anyway?"

"Dad wants it to be a special *father-daughter bonding trip,"* Glimmer said with disdain. "Plus Aunt Casta is really busy with setting up the Academy again, since, you know … no more war, huge magic boom, biggest first-year class in two generations."

"Well, hey," Bow chided, poking a finger in Glimmer's side, "keep an open mind. That does sound like it could be good for you and your dad."

"Ugh," Glimmer groaned. She sat up from her place at Bow's side and looked at him with pleading eyes. "I know it would be good, and I know he means well, but… This is serious, Bow! And we have plenty of other work to do. We have to stay focused until the problem is fixed, and then move on. There's no time for—" her throat stuck on the last word because, honestly, she didn't believe a word she had said so far. "For vacation."

Bow didn't believe it either, and it showed in one unamused, cocked eyebrow.

"Glimmer."

She sighed. "Yes."

"We both know you would never, ever, in a million years pass up a vacation to Mystacor." Glimmer hung her head in shame. Bow's

hands found their way to her shoulders once more. "What's going on here? Are you afraid to spend time with your dad?"

"I'm not afraid!" she defended with a pout. "It's just … weird. He was gone, and now he's here, and it's been a year and it should feel normal now, right? But it doesn't. It's not like I can just start being friends with him. We have nothing to go on, except…" she trailed off, letting the silence say the painful part.

The way Bow's eyebrows pressed together told Glimmer that he heard her loud and clear. "Well then," he tried, "maybe this can be something for you to start with. Something you share that isn't grief."

Glimmer stared at the sheets through her crossed legs, considering. But when she looked back at her boyfriend, he had that look on his face that meant he was planning something.

As a rule, Bow didn't *scheme.* That was Catra's domain, and sometimes Glimmer's. Neither did he *strategize*— that was the word Adora used for what was really just overthinking. No, when Bow made a plan—ever the tinkerer—he simply laid the disparate parts out on the table and found a way to put them together.

"You should bring Catra!" he said, like it was the most obvious thing in the world and not completely out of nowhere.

Glimmer let her mouth hang open for a minute, for effect.

"To Mystacor?! With *my dad?!"*

"Yes!" He squeezed her shoulders for emphasis. "Just think about it. There's someone else there, so it doesn't have to be as awkward with Micah, *and* you get a chance for some good healthy friendship with Catra! Plus," he dropped his tone conspiratorially, "I think Micah kind of wants to be friends with Catra, and I think she does too. So you can make that happen also."

"Bow, that's—" *don't picture Catra in a bathing suit, don't picture Catra in a bathing suit,* "That's insane! It'll be so awkward I won't

even know what to do with myself!”

Bow raised his eyebrow, like he had caught her stealing from a jar of tea cookies. “You said ‘will.’”

“Okay, fine!” Glimmer threw her hands up in surrender. “I’ll ask her. She’ll probably say no, though. You know how she is about water.”

“Who said anything about water?”

In a rush, she picked up a frilly pink pillow and threw it at Bow’s face. *“Shut up!”*

Chapter End Notes

> no illustration this week! next illustration will come on the first day of the big bang so stay tuned.

two more meetings

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

The next time, it was **Glimmer** who found Catra.

The morning briefing had probably been the most awkward in Bright Moon history. Glimmer had completely avoided eye contact with Catra the entire time, even as Catra was giving her report. Micah, clearly befuddled as to what had transpired to create such tension, had simply looked back and forth between the two of them for the duration. And, gods, did Glimmer want to make sure he never, ever caught on.

Now, she made her way through the ministerial offices, checking in on every one of them in a desperate attempt to find something to distract her from the completely bizarre conversation she was about to have. What would you do if you were a bureaucrat, and the head of state—your boss—angrily made out with you in a moonlit garden after you tried to get her to hate you, and then asked you to come to the beach with her and her dad the next day? Nothing in the vastness of the universe could have equipped Glimmer with the necessary mental or emotional faculties to predict the answer to such a question.

But said conversation did seem just about inevitable at this point. None of the ministers had anything out of the ordinary going on, and she had asked after all of them at this point—all but one.

Catra's office was the last door on the right in a long, marble-floored hallway lined with gleaming white columns. Statuesque Bright Moon guards bowed their heads as Glimmer passed. When she reached the end—decorated with an old, barely intelligible mural of a worker harvesting tea leaves—she turned slowly toward Catra's office door.

It was no bigger than any other door in Bright Moon, in fact it was considerably smaller, and only modestly ornamented with mother-of-pearl inlays. But still, it felt much larger as Glimmer raised her fist and knocked—mostly because she was not used to knocking on doors. The knock echoed down the hall like reports from cannonfire.

Catra's voice almost sounded hopeful as she called from behind the door, "Come in!"

Glimmer took a deep breath and plunged into Catra's office. The room was shaded aqua blue by daylight streaming through the stained glass, and Glimmer let herself enjoy it for a moment before she saw Catra behind the desk.

Catra's face, framed perfectly by the hair that her ponytail left behind, was a tense, inscrutable mask. Her nose would scrunch up adorably when she scowled—which was not as often as she once had—but right now the nose-scrunch came unaccompanied by the flash of her teeth. Glimmer followed the lines of her face down to her neck and, *Oh gods,* there was a *big* hickey blooming red and purple near her jugular. Glimmer's face grew hot.

"Hey, Glimmer," Catra said, a little strained. Glimmer noted the omission of a nickname.

"Hi, Catra," said the queen as she examined the carpet for a second. She looked back up at her friend's (?) unreadable expression and quickly decided she needed to make this feel normal. So she straightened her back and folded her hands behind, deepened her voice and said, brilliantly, "How are, um … affairs?"

Catra's cheeks flushed a deep brown under her freckles, then Glimmer quickly corrected, "I—I mean *foreign* affairs. Work."

"Oh. Work." Catra schooled her features back into something like composure. She adjusted some papers on her desk absently.

"Work is … fine. Should be getting word from Mystacor later about whether Greenvale will sign the trade agreement."

"That's good, yeah," muttered Glimmer. She rocked back and forth on her heels and worried her lip for a second before deciding to take the segue. "Hey, speaking of Mystacor—"

Catra's eyebrow quirked up.

"My dad and I are going there next week for some," she paused, sighed, "personal business, and I was thinking … maybe you could come with us?"

"Sparkles," said Catra, unamused, "are you seriously asking me to go on vacation with you?"

Glimmer growled. "It's *not* a vacation. I said 'personal business,' didn't I? We have some serious magic stuff to do. Plus, you're my foreign minister, and, y'know. Diplomacy."

"Sure. Okay. Diplomacy," Catra deadpanned. "But I would be remiss if I didn't ask, Your Glitteriness… Are you intending to angrily swap spit with me again? Because we *really* need to talk about that."

Glimmer just stared at her. She hadn't thought the topic would come up that easily; she had been prepared to broach it tactfully, but apparently Catra wanted to dive in headfirst.

"Fine. We can talk," said Glimmer, closing her eyes and steepling her fingers against the bridge of her nose. She readied herself, opened her eyes and walked over to Catra's desk purposefully.

"Look. I'm … sorry for flipping out like that, okay? I just—there was a lot going on."

Catra nodded, her face neutral, eyes meeting Glimmer's. "It's alright. I think I get it."

"You really didn't, though," Glimmer sighed. She cautiously reached for Catra's hand, which Catra made no effort to withdraw. Her skin felt clammy. "Catra, you—you're my friend. You don't deserve to suffer now for what you did a long time ago."

Catra's ears folded back and she looked away. She still didn't take her hand back, but Glimmer felt her tense.

"I … want you in my life," Glimmer said softly. "And that feeling is so much bigger than the way I used to feel about you. It's bigger than how I feel about my mom, too. I get to decide what's good for me, and Catra—"

Glimmer brought her other hand to Catra's impossibly soft cheek. Catra gasped softly as Glimmer guided her face back towards her own.

"Catra, I think … I think you're good for me."

Catra held her stare with eyes almost glowing. Glimmer let her hand fall from Catra's face and surrounded Catra's hand in an embrace.

"Just because the way you feel about—" Catra gulped, then continued, "Just because your grief is smaller doesn't mean that it doesn't deserve room. You don't have to hide it just because things are different now."

"I know, but…" *It feels childish,* is what Glimmer wanted to say. Because it was, wasn't it? She was the queen, and had been for over two years now. She had even gotten her dad back. Wishing for more than that would have been undeniably selfish. And it wasn't like she really believed that her mother would be able to help her in any concrete way; missing her was an exercise in self-indulgence. It always had been. That's what it had been when Glimmer was taking it out on Catra, though she had wanted to believe the dark, sickly-sweet voice of Shadow Weaver in her head telling her she was only doing what it took to win. She was, in a way—but it had never been about winning *the war.*

In any case, Glimmer was done being selfish. She couldn't have it both ways. If she chose grief, she chose Catra's shame, and her own loneliness. But if she chose Catra, she chose the present. The friends, the family, the *love* she did have, and not the one she had lost.

"I'm choosing you, Catra," was what she finally said, and she put as much weight behind it as she could. "I'm choosing you because grief is a shitty friend. And you're—"

"Less shitty?" Catra said, with a slight smirk. Her blush had returned, and her hand was warm under Glimmer's.

Glimmer smiled. "Marginally less shitty, yes."

"Tell me how you really feel, Princess," Catra drawled. The corner of her mouth curled with mischief. "That kiss felt like a lot more than 'marginally less shitty.'"

"Ugh." Glimmer took her hands back to cover the uncontrollable grin spreading across her lips. "I told you not to read too much into it. It's not happening again."

Catra just shrugged and examined her claws, flexing and stretching her fingers out slowly. The self-satisfied smile on her face softened into something more vulnerable.

"So," said Glimmer after shaking the warmth out of her cheeks, "are you coming to Mystacor or not, Horde Scum?"

Catra turned back to Glimmer, her eyes alight from the blue glow of the stained glass. "Sure, Sparkles," she said, "whatever you want."

When **Catra** told Adora, her reaction was less comforting than Catra had wanted.

"Oh, that sounds great!" said Adora absently as she folded some laundry at the dresser. "You need a vacation."

Catra came to stand next to Adora and examined her face. Her eyebrows were pushed together, her chin scrunched up in concentration as she attempted to perfectly crease the sleeves of one of her collection of identical white undershirts.

"You're not worried that she'll, I don't know," Catra motioned with her hands as her tail thrashed, "try to make out with me again?"

Adora shrugged, not entirely convincingly. "Not really. It seemed like a one-time thing, right? I mean," she chuckled awkwardly, "she has Bow. And she's, like, the queen. And her dad is going to be there too, so she probably wouldn't try anything. Right?" Adora paused her shirt-folding and turned to Catra with a definitely-not-anxious look in her eyes. "Right? You're not supposed to kiss in front of dads, right?"

Catra sighed. "Adora, she literally said 'it's not happening again.' If she tries to go back on that, I'll tell you, but I don't think she will."

Adora released some tension in her shoulders, gave a small smile, then returned to her laundry. Catra ran a finger down her tricep where her tanktop left it exposed.

"When, uh," said Adora, her forehead creased with concentration and—something else, "how long will you be gone?"

"Hm?" said Catra. "Probably not long. Glimmer said it's just some personal stuff she has to take care of, and I don't really have any business to do. Two, three nights maybe. Why, you planning something?"

Adora turned beet-red. "Uh, no!" She forced a laugh. "Definitely not planning anything."

"O…kay. You're not gonna find some other girl to have a fling with?"

"Ha, ha," Adora said dryly. She threw a shirt at Catra's face, then anxiously picked it back up when it fell to the floor. "No. I'm just

… curious, is all. Can't a girl be curious about her girlfriend's travel plans?"

"Yeah, but I mean…" Catra brushed a stray hair behind Adora's ear. "You just seem like you're worried about something."

Adora sighed, then looked at Catra straight on. "Look, I've just been feeling weird, okay? And Mystacor is a weird place, and weird and bad stuff has happened there before."

An unwelcome memory bubbled up in Catra's mind—the Failsafe. Her muscles froze.

"Just be careful, okay?" said Adora, gently laying a rough palm on Catra's cheek, the same one that Glimmer had touched earlier.

She couldn't help but lean into Adora's hand, even as she waited for her blood to thaw. Once she felt the warmth in her face again, Catra whispered into Adora's hand, "I will. Promise. I'll keep in touch on the mini-pad and Melog can let you know if I'm in distress."

"Okay," Adora sighed, then planted a kiss on Catra's other cheek. "Nothing to worry about."

And it was true, there was nothing to worry about. The past was complicated, and full of dark, ugly, complicated things, but none of that had any power here. This was the bright future. This was the happily ever after. All the things with bloody claws were just memories. Grief was a shitty friend, like Glimmer said, so Catra was giving grief the cold shoulder.

She was going to Mystacor, and nothing was going to stop her from enjoying it. No shadows, no villains, and no doomed heroes. It would be a simple joy, and Catra wasn't about to let anything complicate that.

Keeping it simple, as it turned out, was easier said than done.

In the few days leading up to their trip, Catra did absolutely everything in her power to avoid being alone with Glimmer again. Not for fear of another weird kiss—that possibility she had to put out of her mind—but to avoid any more unplanned emotional intimacy. Catra, after all, was a survivor, and you don't survive by seeking out the things that hurt you.

Glimmer might have said she was choosing Catra over her own grief, but Catra knew better than anybody that grief tends to be clingy. It follows you around. You can pretend it's not there all you want, but it's hard to ignore when it breathes down your neck. So, Catra simply avoided putting Glimmer's grief and her own in a room together.

The complicating factor that Catra failed to take into account was Micah.

She was packing her files up after a morning briefing. The usual chorus of hushed conversations echoed through the open doors and into the council room as bureaucrats, princesses, and politicians made their ways out.

Adora's hand brushed hers, and Catra looked up to find that familiar softness in her eyes.

"Going straight to the office?" Adora asked quietly, adding her own voice to the post-meeting chatter.

Catra smiled and shook her head. "Not necessarily. Meet you back at our place?"

"Sounds good." Adora leaned over and kissed Catra's cheek. She smiled giddily, even as she walked away and said over her shoulder, "I'll see you there."

Catra returned to shuffling her files into place. She was about to shove everything into her messenger bag when she realized she wasn't the only one left in the meeting room.

Her eyes found the King of Bright Moon still sitting in the tall chair next to his daughter's, which had been quickly vacated after the meeting. (Glimmer had cited some bullshit about needing to pack.) He looked at Catra with a question in his eyes, and she looked back with no answers.

"Hi, Catra," he said, his tone neutral in a way Catra didn't like. "Could you stick around for a second? I wanted to talk to you about our trip to Mystacor."

Catra forced herself to place her messenger bag back on the table and relax her shoulders. *Keep it simple.*

"Sure, Your Majesty." She chased any hint of nervousness out of her voice. "What is it?"

He cocked his head. "You know you don't have to call me that, right?"

Catra wasn't sure if she was supposed to answer that, but Micah moved on too quickly for her to think about it too much. He stood up, never taking his eyes off her, and approached her slowly, like she might startle if he were too sudden.

"Listen, Catra," he said once he was close enough that she could see his stubble. "I know that I'm Glimmer's dad, and you might feel weird about me because of … everything—"

Understatement of the millennium, she almost said, but her nervousness forced her tongue to stay.

"But you're really important to her," he continued. "To Glimmer. And I don't want you to feel like you're intruding on anything by coming with us. In fact," he said quieter, casting his eyes toward the table and rubbing his neck in a very un-kingly way, "I was sort of hoping we could get to know each other better, too."

"I, uh," Catra stumbled as her thoughts attempted to catch up with everything Micah had just said. This felt completely out of the blue—Micah was supposed to be the level-headed, dadly king.

Or, kingly dad. He was the voice of reason, the dispenser of non-specific platitudes. Vulnerability was *not* on the menu. Catra tried to keep her ears and tail still as she thought of a clean escape.

"Yep, sounds good," was what she eventually settled on. It wasn't really how she felt, but it would get her out of the room. She nodded politely, then turned around and headed for the door, mumbling over her shoulder, "Gotta go, see you soon!"

His face fell, but Catra tried not to notice. Then, as she reached the threshold, he called after her: "We have more in common than just Glimmer, you know."

That froze Catra in her place. Something told her to turn around and look Micah in the eyes, and she obeyed. He looked somber, like someone running into a friend at a funeral. A bolt of cold ran down Catra's spine. Before Micah even spoke again, Catra already knew what he was talking about, deep in her bones.

"Before she joined the Horde," he said, and Catra didn't have to ask who *she* was, "before she … raised you and Adora, she was my teacher. My mentor, when I was a kid in Mystacor."

Catra could only nod as Micah continued.

"She manipulated me. Told me I was special, that I was better than the others. She used me. She could have killed me. It was lucky she never got to Casta or any of the other kids. I was the only one. But then…" His eyes went glassy and unfocused as he recounted all of this, but then suddenly sharpened and looked straight into Catra's. "I wasn't, was I?"

Every painful moment of Catra's childhood flashed before her eyes. Every moment she had been told she was ruining perfect, special Adora, every minute spent paralyzed and buzzing with cold, dark magic, every night curled up in a ball on Adora's cot so nobody could touch her softer spots. And then, the other side: watching Adora do the unimaginable, leave Catra behind, throw herself to the front lines, run headfirst into danger, sacrifice

herself because the old sorceress had convinced her that she was the only one strong enough.

No, Micah hadn't been the only one. Catra found his eyes again and shook her head hard enough that he wouldn't notice the tears at the edges of her eyes.

Micah started approaching her slowly again. "The damage she did to me over only a few years was… It's more than I care to talk about most days. Adora told me what it was like for you two growing up with her. I can't possibly imagine it."

Catra's throat tightened with the threat of a sob, and the tears began to spill down her cheeks. She turned away, back toward the open door.

"Just know that, if you ever want to talk about it," Micah said, almost in a whisper, "I'll be there."

Catra thought about facing him again, but before she could turn around, there was a hand on her shoulder. She could feel through her shirt that it was large, probably the right size for Micah, but—something wasn't right about it. It was cold. Bony. And Catra could have sworn, it had nails that were just a bit too sharp.

So instead, she ran.

From that moment on, the cold never quite left Catra. Even in bed with Adora the night before leaving for Mystacor, wrapped up in strong arms and unrelenting warmth, there was a shiver always threatening to shake her spine. Sleep was too shallow, dreamless but not restful, and when she woke, the daylight through the open window was too bright.

Melog blinked up at her as she shuffled through the closet as quietly as possible, packing her overnight bag. They made a gentle sound that whispered meaning into her head.

What are you afraid of, Catra?

She paused her frantic packing to look at the cat, their eyes and mane a cautious violet color. They were clued in to the strange feelings Catra had been having, but that didn't mean Catra had words for them. Though she had been working on it, there were still times like this when parts of her were shrouded in opaque shadow, defying rationalization.

"It's nothing, Melog."

Catra shook her head clear of the creeping anxiety and finished packing, zipped her bag closed and shut the closet behind her. She squatted to Melog's height and ran a hand through their misty mane.

"Look after Adora for me, okay?" she said gently. Melog chirped in agreement. "Make sure she eats and sleeps enough. You know how she gets."

They blinked slowly and mewed again. *I will let you know if anything is wrong. And I will alert her if I sense you are in any danger.*

"Thanks, buddy." She smiled politely as she stood, then made her way toward the door, stopping by the bed first to press a soft kiss against Adora's sleeping cheek.

Adora mumbled, barely awake, and it almost broke Catra's heart that she had to go. But she would be back soon, and everything would be fine. She brought her mouth to the shell of Adora's ear and whispered one last promise before she left to meet Glimmer and Micah on the lawn.

Chapter End Notes

> Big Bang starts on Sunday the 9th! You guys ready to see where this goes?

another meeting, and a study in statuary

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

In Etheria's very short autumn season, Mystacor tended to be cold and blustery—more so than usual, that is, with it floating several thousand feet above sea level. As Glimmer, Catra, and Micah walked through its cavernous halls—lined with open windows for some reason **Catra** couldn't explain—the gusts caused the gossamer curtains to billow into the corridor, making it almost like walking through mist.

"Our rooms are just up here," said Micah. "I tried to get three rooms but apparently Casta doesn't take the whole 'royalty' thing very seriously, so she only gave us two. One has two beds and the other has one."

"I'll take the single," Catra said quickly. The simple solution.

Or maybe not. Glimmer shot her a nervous look, then before Catra could take back her apparently wrong choice, Micah bumped his daughter on the shoulder.

"Guess it's you and me then, huh, babygirl?"

She returned his gesture with a strained smile and a chuckle. "Yep. You and me, Dad."

So, it was possible this arrangement would be awkward for Glimmer. Still, it was better than the alternative: Catra and Glimmer sharing a room. That was all kinds of complicated. And Catra sharing a room with *Micah* … after their conversation the day before, she had planned on never being alone with him again. It wasn't that he had been acting weird, objectively: it made sense that he would want to talk to Catra about the figure who tied their histories together. But something about it had felt too

close, like her memory was still too recent and if Catra talked about, even *thought* about her too much, she might—

Just as Catra had this thought, she passed an intersecting corridor, this one much taller and broader. On one side it was lined with huge marble statues, and on the other with more billowing curtains. It was the Hall of Sorcerers, she remembered—the one where all of the Guild's head sorcerers were memorialized. Catra's eyes fell on the face of Castaspella first, posed elegantly with one stone hand against her breast and the other presenting a shining four-pointed star—then, none other than Micah himself, though much younger than he was now, and wearing the traditional head sorcerer's robes instead of his royal tunic.

And then, about halfway down the hall, a third statue: this one darkened by something more than just age and neglect. It was her—Light Spinner, that is, but still *her.* Catra knew this almost instinctively, without even having to see the statue's pointed ears, bony hands tipped with sharp nails, or long waves of hair.

In the split second before Light Spinner's statue passed out of view, a length of sheer fabric fluttered in front of its face, causing thin shadows to dance across it—and Catra could have sworn that as she watched, the statue's eyes pointed back at her.

Glimmer threw her several suitcases haphazardly at the foot of a bed, one of an identical pair in the spacious Mystacor guest suite. It was supposed to be *her* bed, in theory, but that thought was difficult to process. She reasoned that staying in guest rooms always felt strange on the first night. Her father set his single bag down at the foot of the other one and took a deep breath of the crisp, cool air.

"So, what first? Steam grotto? Sushi bar?" he asked with a childish excitement in his voice.

Glimmer wished she could meet his enthusiasm. Their official reason for being here still occupied the fore of her mind. Being

without her spells wasn't as bad as being stuck in space without any magic at all, but it still left her partly vulnerable.

"Let's just go talk to Aunt Casta first," Glimmer said, attempting some queenly finality. "We can relax once we've figured out what's going on with our magic. I'll go check up on Catra and let her know where we're going."

Before Micah could protest, Glimmer called on the Moonstone and blinked out of the room. When she opened her eyes again, she was in an almost identical one, except with one bed instead of two. But Catra was nowhere in sight.

Glimmer noticed the door to the en suite bathroom hanging open and heard the sink running, so she flashed over to it, simultaneously calling out, "Catra?"

Catra's surprised shriek was much more shrill than usual, and all at once Glimmer remembered she didn't like people sneaking up on her—but the reason for Catra's reaction was probably, Glimmer realized, because she was standing in the tub with a wet washcloth, completely nude.

Glimmer gasped, then covered her face, blushing hotter than a bonfire. "Sorry!" she squeaked out from between her hands.

"Get the fuck out, Sparkles!" Catra ordered, her anger only thinly covering up her embarrassment.

Glimmer turned around before delivering her message on one strained breath. "Dad and I are going to talk to Aunt Casta now we'll be at her office it's next to the Lunarium text me if you need anything!"

Just as quickly as she had arrived, a flash of light carried Glimmer out of the room, her head still in her hands.

Okay, so—Glimmer had seen **Catra** naked. It couldn't have been for more than half a second, but still, it had happened.

Catra had to turn the water down to its coldest setting to keep the heat from spreading all the way to her toes. Once she finished thoroughly scrubbing herself with a little more vigor than was strictly necessary, she toweled off, ran her claws through her damp hair and pulled it back into a low ponytail. She managed to dress herself comfortably without thinking too much about Glimmer's eyes on her.

Despite all the extra effort taken to relax herself, she couldn't lie still when she tried settling in for a nap. She felt … *worked up.* It was a hard feeling to trace back to any single cause. Part of it definitely had to do with the thought that she was technically on a business trip and her boss had just ogled her, along with everything else that had already happened between them. But it wasn't only that. There was an unease about being here that stuck in Catra's throat. Seeing the statue of Light Spinner—and the undeniable feeling of *being seen* by it in turn—might have ensured that Catra had no chance of truly relaxing on this trip.

She tossed and turned to one side, and noticed her mini-pad on the bedside table. The screen was lit up with a message: *From: Dummy<3*

Adora, arriving just in time to save her as usual. Catra reached for the pad and swiped the message open. A smile spread across her lips as she read, the love cascading through her and setting her hair on end, an antidote to the anxiety.

hey babe! i'm working today so i can't talk much, but just wanted to remind you that i love you <3 ttyl!

Catra's thumb danced across the screen as she composed her reply:

love you too goober <3 have fun defense minister-ing. i'll make sure to take a steam bath long enough for both of us.

Satisfied, Catra set the mini-pad on the table again, face-down. She rolled onto her back and stared at the high, dark-painted

ceiling, speckled with white and yellow to simulate stars. A steam bath might not be a bad idea, she thought. But she had just had a regular bath. She weighed the options in her mind and decided on a compromise: a walk to the steam grotto, a quick stroll through the warm mist, and then back.

Maybe she could relax, after all.

Castaspella's office was the very same one that head sorcerers had been occupying for centuries since the Guild's founding. As such, it was large, full of books and crystals containing records of those centuries, and smelled strongly of stale incense and patchouli oil—a scent which had soaked deep into the hand-embroidered cushions of the high-backed chairs which Glimmer and Micah now sat in.

"Thanks again for seeing us, Casta. I know you're very busy," Micah said, only a little perturbed.

"Of course, of course," Castaspella replied as she settled in her seat behind the ancient oaken desk. "Anything for my big brother and my little Glimmer. I am sorry about the accommodations by the way—I just didn't realize you'd be bringing Catra until too late, and then the only other empty room I had available developed a strange mold problem."

"Ah, the one behind the Hall of Sorcerers, right?" said Micah. "That one's had problems since before I was head sorcerer."

"You understand, then. Centuries-old buildings do tend to have strange things in the walls." As Castaspella said this, her tone shifted into the same one she had used to tell Glimmer ghost stories as a child, and her eyes flashed with mischief in Glimmer's direction.

"Can we just talk about what's going on please, Aunt Casta?" Glimmer said. "I'd like to get this over with so I can relax."

Castaspella clapped her hands together in front of her and smiled beatifically. Her patience for Glimmer's temper had always been admirable.

"Yes, yes, of course. Why don't you tell me what's been going on?"

Micah turned to Glimmer and nodded at her, insisting she explain. With her eyebrows pinched together in self-consciousness, she cleared her throat and began, "Well, basically, whenever Dad or I go to cast a spell—even a simple one—it just sort of … fizzles out in the air. I can feel the magic just fine, and there's plenty of it, but when I try to channel it, it's like everything stops cold."

"I see." Castaspella steepled her fingers in front of her face, fiddled with the rings holding the sleeves of her robe down, and hummed. "Well, I'm sure both of you know, there are a number of things that can prevent a sorcerer from tapping into the magic around them. Obviously your runes and sigils must be drawn accurately, you must have a deep knowledge of the traditions, the meanings and magical properties of symbols and spell ingredients —but you're both very accomplished sorcerers already…"

Micah sighed. "Yes, Casta. Some might even say we're the *most* accomplished." He tapped the golden four-pointed star on his tunic, a symbol of his emeritus status in the Guild.

Castaspella waved the gesture away. "Sure, sure, I'm just … going over the basics." She smiled sweetly at him. "In case you need a refresher."

"I—"

"Anyway," Castaspella continued, "the only thing I can imagine that would be stopping you would be if…" she paused and looked at Glimmer, "Your motivations and intentions weren't clear enough."

"What are you trying to say, Aunt Casta?" Glimmer growled.

"Nothing at all, Glimmer. It's just…" She looked away and began fiddling with her sleeves again. "Considering where most of your —" she cleared her throat, " *training* came from, I wouldn't be surprised if the intentions behind your magic are a little … shall we say, obscured?"

"Are you suggesting my daughter is some kind of dark magician?" Micah accused, a somewhat extreme interpretation from Glimmer's perspective.

Castaspella scoffed. "Heavens, no! And I find it extremely distasteful to mention such things in my office. I'm just saying that, since Shadow Weaver influenced you both very early on in your training," Micah flinched visibly at the mention of her name, "she may have taught you to relate to your magic in some *unsavory* ways that could prevent you from functioning normally."

Micah stroked his beard and hummed, then said, "If that were the case, it would make no sense for it to be happening now. I can't think of anything that's changed that would bring that out. *If* it's true, I mean. I'm very doubtful about it."

Glimmer looked at him, and he at her. Out of some shadowy place in Glimmer's mind, a thought came that was simply too frightening to leave unsaid.

"What if it's coming from an outside source?" she said, keeping her eyes on her father for his reaction. He looked at her with confusion, which then gave way to an uncertain—and perhaps unwilling—understanding.

"Then why would it only be affecting you two?" Castaspella said incredulously. "If something was going on in the magical atmosphere, wouldn't it—"

"I don't mean something is going on with Etheria, Aunt Casta." Glimmer looked straight into her aunt's eyes and made her tone darker, giving into the drama of it. "I mean what if some *one* is doing this to us? What if it's a curse?"

Immediately, Castaspella straightened her back and set her face sternly. "I won't tolerate talk of such things. There aren't any sorcerers in the world with the power or the wickedness to do something like that—not anymore. Besides, it would require the caster to have some kind of physical … stuff. Bits of you. Neither of you have given anybody your hair or blood recently, have you?"

"No, but—" Glimmer began, but Castaspella cut her off.

"Exactly. So, no curse. End of discussion."

"It was a valid question, Casta," Micah said, though he sounded doubtful of this. "Don't stifle her like that."

"Micah, you know as well as I do that we have a zero-tolerance policy for dark magic, and for *very* good reason. I can't entertain notions like that." She turned to Glimmer, and her tone became patronizing. "Glimmer, if you want to talk to someone about … *occult superstitions,* your father can show you where to go. *Her* office is in the library. I will have no part of it."

"Because you hate dark magic, or because you're still feuding with Mortella?" Micah asked, and this suggestion turned Castaspella's face bright red.

"Micah!" Castaspella whisper-yelled. "Not in front of Glimmer!"

"She's not a kid anymore, Casta. I think she can stand to hear about the grudge you hold against your ex."

Glimmer's eyebrows shot up her face, and she battled a giggle in her throat.

Castaspella slapped her desk angrily. "It's not a grudge, Micah! She turned me into a little old lady for a whole week!"

"You broke up with her by messenger pigeon! In the *dining hall!"*

"Only because she kept hitting on you," Castaspella defended, her arms now crossed over her chest like a defiant toddler.

Micah held his hands up in surrender. “Hey, we were good friends. It was never like that. Besides, how could she resist … this?” In an instant, Micah turned away from Castaspella, and then back to her with his lips pursed in an embarrassing attempt at a smolder.

Glimmer nearly fell out of her smelly old chair.

A relaxing walk to the steam grotto. That’s all it was supposed to have been. But nothing **Catra** did was ever as simple as it sounded. Instead of strolling through the warm mist, Catra was frozen stock-still in a hallway, staring up.

She should have remembered that she would have to walk this way to get to the steam grotto. All of Mystacor’s tourist attractions were on one easy route to avoid getting caught up in droves of students and apprentices. The gardens, the beaches, the Lunarium, the steam grotto—and the Hall of Sorcerers.

She had tried to avert her eyes as she passed the Light Spinner statue again, but it had been no use. The memorial’s stony gaze was piercing somehow, even though it didn’t move (and it didn’t—Catra had checked) and had no color other than the dark grime that coated the marble.

Catra was no expert in statuary, but she didn’t have to be: the comparisons drew themselves. This was the second statue Catra had seen this week of a woman who had raised a wartime leader and sacrificed herself for the Rebellion. It was a dark reflection of the first one she had seen, that of Queen Angella in the gardens at Castle Bright Moon.

“I’m not afraid of you,” Catra whispered to the statue. “You don’t control me anymore.”

She hardly believed the words from her own mouth.

Another thought, even more troubling, came to her then. The woman who was once supposed to have been her guardian—she may not have had any means to control Catra anymore, but that

didn’t negate the fact that Catra was alive *because* of her. Before, Catra had always been alive *in spite* of the sorceress, but now, after her sacrifice in the Heart, Catra *owed her life* to this woman. And when someone dies in your place, isn’t it the least you can do to honor the debt?

Catra didn’t go to the steam grotto that afternoon. The thought of purposefully losing her senses was too terrifying to bear.

Chapter End Notes

> ONE CHAPTER EVERY DAY THIS WEEK LET'S FUCKING GOOOOO

watching shadows

Chapter Summary

minor warning for blood in this chapter.

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

After an early dinner at the sushi bar, Micah had gone to the occult specialist Mortella's office to schedule an appointment with her the next day, leaving **Glimmer** alone with Catra once again.

Catra laid on the bed, stared at the ceiling, and periodically checked her mini-pad. She seemed anxious—Glimmer figured it had something to do with the incident in the bathroom earlier, which had significantly reignited the tension between them. Glimmer sat on the floor a good distance from the bed to avoid said tension, and painted her nails while she tried to distract Catra with the details of her and Micah's magic problem.

"So, I suggested, what if it's a curse?" Glimmer said as she steadied her hand for another stroke of purple polish on her big toe. "And Aunt Casta was all like, 'Grr, no curses!' Because she's like, really serious about not talking about dark magic and stuff."

Catra hummed distractedly while staring at her mini-pad screen.

"But like, it's the best theory anyone's had so far," Glimmer continued. "I really don't think it has anything to do with the fact that Shadow Weaver taught us both."

Glimmer thought she heard Catra gasp and looked up to the bed from her careful nail-painting—but Catra's face remained as bored-looking as ever.

And it wasn't what Glimmer wanted, for Catra to be uninterested, detached. What she wanted, she realized, was for Catra to tell her

it would be okay, that they would figure it out if they just kept trying. She wanted a gentle voice and a gentle hand she knew and trusted. She wanted…

"I wish my mom were here," Glimmer said quietly, without really meaning to.

Then, when Glimmer glanced up at Catra, her face was taut with guilt. Glimmer could tell from the clench of her fist that Catra was fighting the urge to run out of the room.

"I'm sorry, Catra, I don't mean it like that. I'm glad you're here. I just mean…" Glimmer trailed off and examined the floor, trying to decide what exactly she meant. "She always knew what to do, you know? When it came to magic, I mean. She taught me how to use the Moonstone. She taught me everything she knew about Etheria and its magic, which was, like, a lot."

Catra nodded slowly, took a deep breath. "Yeah, I think I get it."

This prompted Glimmer to carefully put away the nail brush and abandon her pedicure. She stood—a bit awkwardly, to avoid any damage to the wet polish—and sat next to Catra on the bed. Catra watched her nervously, so Glimmer stayed turned away, and simply laid her hand over Catra's on the mattress.

Glimmer chuckled. "If only we had another ancient, immortal, celestial being with hundreds of years of knowledge about all Etheria's mysteries."

"We have She-Ra," Catra said with a tentative smirk in her voice.

"I'm not convinced wisdom is one of She-Ra's powers."

Catra let out a genuine laugh at that, squeaky and musical. Glimmer couldn't help but smile quietly.

Feeling heartened, Glimmer started again. "Did I mention my dad is off talking to my aunt's ex-girlfriend right now?"

A dramatic gasp from Catra, then, "No. Way."

Glimmer turned around and met Catra's mischievous eyes. "Yes way! How weird is that?"

"You think it's weird that your aunt has an ex?" Catra said. Her eyebrow lifted in a way that suggested she had more to say.

"I mean," Glimmer said cautiously, "a little. I don't know. I guess I just never thought of her as being someone who … *dates* people."

Catra bared her fangs in a smile. "Are you kidding? Casta is smokin' hot, of course she dates people. She has that middle-aged sexy factor."

"Catra!" Glimmer shrieked. She slapped Catra's arm playfully. "You have a girlfriend!"

"You have a boyfriend," Catra shot back, giggling. "That doesn't stop you from finding *me* super hot."

Glimmer sputtered, becoming increasingly flustered and trying to find a comeback, but Catra didn't let her.

"Look, all I'm saying is that your family has some good-ass genes."

"You little shit!"

With that, Glimmer commenced tickling Catra aggressively. They both laughed riotously, tumbling over each other as they jabbed fingers at each other's sides. The edge of the bed snuck up on them and they crashed into the spongy carpet on the floor, Catra first, and then Glimmer on top of her.

There was a pause in their laughter allowing Glimmer and Catra to each catch their breath, and that was when it became apparent to Glimmer that she was much closer to Catra than she had intended. Glimmer's knees bracketed Catra's narrow hips and her elbows boxed in Catra's head. Her dark, plush lips were *right*

there, and the realization shot an unfortunate bolt of heat to the apex of Glimmer's legs, resting against Catra's lower stomach. This position could have been charitably described as *compromising,* and they both realized it, judging by the widening of Catra's pupils and the darkening of her cheeks.

It would have been a perfectly horrible time for Micah to enter the room, which of course, he did.

Catra lies on the floor, Glimmer straddles her, and both blush as Micah walks in the door.

"Oh," said the King of Bright Moon, and his daughter screamed.

She frantically climbed off Catra and attempted to compose herself. Catra, looking bewildered, stayed prone on the carpet.

"Sorry, I can, uh … come back. If you need some time," Micah said quietly, half-hiding behind the door.

"No!" Glimmer shouted, then more quietly, "No. Nothing is happening, we're … You're fine. What's up?"

Micah cleared his throat. "I got an appointment with Mortella tomorrow, after lunch." He paused, his eyes flitting momentarily to Catra on the floor, then to the bed, then back to Glimmer. "Are you, uh, coming back to our room, sweetie? It's getting late."

Glimmer's face heated up again. She looked down to Catra, who gave her a questioning look, then back to her father. "Um. Maybe later."

"Okay," Micah said with a sigh. The clear disappointment on his face cut into Glimmer's heart, but she bore it. He leaned back out of the room and shut the door behind him.

"Are you afraid of your dad?"

When Glimmer looked back at Catra then, she was sitting up, all evidence of embarrassment or worry gone from her face. It had

been replaced by a look Glimmer knew well, because it was usually directed at bumbling ambassadors: the slight squint, the furrowed brow, the corners of the mouth turned down. Catra saw right down to her center.

"What? No," Glimmer said automatically. "I'm not afraid of my dad, that's ridiculous." She chuckled a little, tried to sell it, but it was no use.

Catra inched closer to her. "You're afraid of being close with him."

Glimmer hung her head silently.

"Why?"

She looked back at Catra. It was a genuine question, Glimmer realized, not meant to embarrass or ridicule her. Catra truly wanted to know.

But did she? Because the answer to this question was not something that would feel good for Catra to hear. It made sense, sure, but it made sense in the way that you can look at the wreckage from an accident and see exactly where every ugly, twisted piece came from.

Catra was smart. If Glimmer didn't tell her, she would guess on her own. At least this way, Glimmer could share the guilt.

"I'm afraid of being close with him," she said quietly, looking back down at the carpet, "because I'm afraid I might love him, and then I might lose him again. Like I lost Mom."

She heard Catra's breath stop. When Glimmer met her gaze again, Catra's lip had started to tremble.

They both said, at the same time, "I'm sorry."

"What do you have to be sorry for?" asked Catra. The tremble made its way into her voice. "I'm the one who took her from you. I'm the reason you're afraid."

Glimmer countered quickly. “You’re not, though. I’m sorry because I know that it hurts for you to see me hurt like this, and I don’t want to hurt you too. This all started way before I even knew who you were. I grew up with this.”

Catra just stared at her, mouth hanging slightly open, those blue and gold eyes turning glassy but still seeing everything, every jagged shard that Glimmer had thought she’d long since hidden away.

“Can you stop staring at me like that?” Glimmer said quietly, she hoped not too forcefully.

Catra turned away quickly, as if she had been slapped. Her response was a mumbled, “Sorry.”

“Ugh.” Glimmer shuffled back over toward Catra. Slowly and gently, making sure Catra saw her, she placed a hand on the other woman’s cheek and guided her eyes back towards her own. “I’m sorry. I didn’t mean to snap.”

“It’s okay,” Catra whispered, her lips barely moving. Her hand came up to meet Glimmer’s on her cheek and lace their fingers together. She guided Glimmer’s hand away, lingering intentionally. “That’s enough sorries for one night, huh?”

Glimmer smiled. “Yeah, I think so.”

They held eye contact for a silent moment, then Catra breathed a sigh. “I should probably, uh … go to bed.”

“Right,” Glimmer said. She let her smile fade. Sleep did sound nice, but being alone with Micah still did not. She cursed her aunt and the mysterious mold problem in the third guest room for forcing this choice on her. Then, just as Catra started getting up to crawl back into bed, Glimmer asked, “Can I sleep in here, actually?”

If Catra blushed, Glimmer couldn’t see. She froze in place with the covers fisted in one hand. She spoke hurriedly.

"Uh, sure."

Being what she was, **Catra** could see fairly well in the dark. It was yet another part of her that seemed to have been designed specifically to make her dangerous. She could follow a target silently in the dead of night until she was right behind them, strike quickly and lethally, and make a clean escape, all while being perfectly aware of every part of her surroundings.

This had been very useful for her prehistoric ancestors. It was not as useful to her as a bureaucrat. Nor was it useful when she was trying to fall asleep next to her—very beautiful, although she would never say that out loud—former nemesis, friend, and now boss, the Queen of Bright Moon.

She tried not to look at Glimmer's back, covered in a thin layer of pink satin. She tried very, very, very hard. She alternated between closing her eyes and, when that failed, looking just about everywhere else in the Mystacor guest room.

The corners of the room Catra found very interesting, in part because they appeared just a little bit darker than they should have, given the dim moonlight streaming in the window. They were blurry, almost, like someone had smudged some grease on a security camera lens. She didn't think about it much. That is, until she began to hear voices in the hall. Just one voice, when she listened closer.

Catra's hearing was even more advanced than her sight, but she could only barely make out what the voice was saying, even with her eyes closed:

"… Never thanked me. Saved your life. Saved hers too. Saved everybody. But you never thanked me. Saved your life. Saved hers too. Saved everybody. But …"

The words froze Catra's spine solid. The more she listened to the voice, she realized, the more it lacked the qualities of a voice in a

hallway—the echo, the retreating or drawing nearer and the matching sound of footsteps. Instead, it was just muffled, like someone speaking into a pillow. Or, more accurately, into a wall. Into a corner.

Her eyes shot back open to the smudged corner. There, without a doubt, a shadow began to twitch. Its edges seemed to dash out and back in again, like something within the shadow was poking through a shroud, testing its solidity. The voice grew louder, more insistent.

"I saved your life. I saved hers too. I saved everybody. But you never thank me."

Catra tried to cover her ears, but found that her arms would not move. She commanded them with all her might, but they ignored her, lying like useless rocks on the mattress. She tried just as hard to stop herself from recognizing the voice, but it became unavoidable when the voice said, *"Catra. My child."*

Her eyes felt like they had been glued open as she watched the shadow in the corner suddenly develop two gray, smokey slits where its eyes might have been, and above that a faintly glowing red spot.

She had no control of the rest of her body, arrested by some unknowable force like the command of a chip or the grip of a shadow, but Catra's voice seemed ready to obey. She screamed. Catra screamed and screamed until she couldn't hear the voice anymore. But still, something made it through.

"Catra!"

Tears streamed down her face as she continued to scream, but she heard it again. This time, she realized it was a different voice than before.

"Catra! Wake up!"

Different, but still malicious. Catra could hear the anger, the hoarseness. Finally, she managed to shut her eyes, block out the dark visions, focus on her body. Focus on the things that made her dangerous.

Her claws came out on command, sinking into the mattress like flesh. Then, without opening her eyes, Catra seized upward, forward, claws first.

She expected to find nothing, but instead she found something warm, something that smelled faintly of strawberries. It wrapped around her, tightly but not threateningly, slowing her down, down, down…

"Catra!"

Her eyes shot open and sitting there, in front of her, on top of her, was Glimmer, eyes wide and cheeks red with panic.

"Catra, can you hear me?"

She nodded.

Glimmer released her grip on Catra's wrists, which Catra had not even realized she had. She winced, as if in pain, but it went away too quickly for Catra to take complete stock of it.

"You were screaming bloody murder. You probably woke up the guards with that," Glimmer said as she climbed off Catra's lap and sat cross-legged on the mattress. "What was that?"

"Uh," Catra started, but her voice was too hoarse to talk. She wet her throat, then tried again. "Nightmare, I think."

"Hell of a nightmare. You get those a lot?"

Catra looked away, back toward the corner where the shadow had stood. It was clear now, the right amount of moonlight exposing all its plainness.

"Yeah. Kind of."

A hand on Catra's knee startled her, her tail puffing out embarrassingly, but it was warm and soft. Comforting. She looked back to Glimmer, whose eyes were heavy with sleep but still sweet.

"You're okay, alright? Nothing's gonna hurt you here." Glimmer's fingers gently traced through the thin hair on Catra's leg. "And never worry about waking me up. I'll always be here if you need me."

Catra's ears folded back and her posture shrank slightly. Not even sleeping with Adora managed to keep away the nightmares, although they were at least not as bad as they had been tonight. Glimmer's presence was … nice, but it wasn't enough to make Catra feel at ease. Only Adora gave that feeling to her, the feeling of being *home.* Glimmer felt more like a hiding place, a temporary refuge that nobody else knew about. Safe, for a time, but bound to be interrupted when the world caught up with her again.

Still, it was what Catra had right now. She would count her blessings.

"Thanks, Sparkles."

Glimmer smiled absently, as if remembering something, then said, "Get some sleep, Horde Scum."

Catra nodded and let herself fall backward onto the cool pillow. Glimmer curled up next to her, just out of reach, facing her this time. Catra let her eyes fall closed, let her breathing slow again, focused on the sound of the distant waves syncopated with Glimmer's own breaths. As Catra fell asleep again, she felt certain that Glimmer was watching her.

Despite the interruption the previous night, the morning of their appointment with Mortella progressed with relative ease. **Glimmer** woke up mid-morning with a gentle, moist breeze

blowing through the window, and Catra followed shortly after. They got ready for the day, keeping a respectful, professional distance from one another as they cleaned up and dressed for brunch.

This respectful distance allowed Glimmer to tend to the only complication of the morning: the small but surprisingly deep wound in her left side from where one of Catra's claws had found purchase. It had absolutely been an accident—Catra had been having some kind of night terror, after all, she couldn't have known she would hit Glimmer. No harm done. Except for the blood.

During her allotted time in the en suite bathroom, Glimmer took a wet cloth to her nightgown to try and remove most of the stain. It didn't work very well, of course—she recalled hearing something about how blood is one of the hardest stains to remove, and requires some kind of special treatment that she obviously did not have access to right then. So, after she changed, she folded the nightgown to very discreetly hide the stain, and retreated to Micah's room— *her* and Micah's room, in theory but not yet in practice.

She exchanged amicable words with her father for a minute or two as he finished getting ready, then when the time came, she fetched Catra and they all three walked in sunlit halls to the private dining room together.

Brunch was quick, but not rushed. The food was delicious, but not too heavy. The conversation was simple, easy: plans for the day, hopes for the rest of the week after this magic business was taken care of. Glimmer let herself relax into a familiar rhythm established by memories of time spent in Mystacor. There was a happy nostalgia in the air, like rediscovering an old friend.

This, of course, was interrupted when they ventured into a part of Mystacor that Glimmer had never cared for much: the cold, dry, oddly dark library on the lower floors under the Lunarium. As they

passed through its arched entrance, emblazoned with a dedication to the late head sorcerer Caprus Norwyn, it felt very similar to how Glimmer imagined descending into the underworld might feel. The upper floors were relatively normal library stuff, everything rendered in granite and wood, carved and painted intricately with Mystacor's purples and blues: the circulation desk, the stacks of newly updated textbooks, the quiet study areas. But as they ventured deeper and deeper, the library seemed to swallow them and pass them into its dark and musty guts.

The windows became scarcer, the stacks denser and their volumes older. Tables with chairs meant for friendly study groups were replaced by solitary desks that looked like they had been in the same spots for a couple hundred years. The colors all faded into grays and browns and the air became thick with the smell of very old paper and the chemicals used to preserve it. On the very bottom floor, the darkest and smelliest of them all, only one part of the towering wall was left exposed between the bookcases, wherein stood an unassuming door. It was old, like the rest of the place, but its hinges were shiny with grease, and there was a light coming from under it.

A single row of letters carved into the wood indicated who dwelled within: *M. Meziani, Occult Sciences.*

"She's going to seem a little weird to you at first," Micah said very softly, holding his fist up to the door in hesitation, "but she's a lovely woman once you get to know her. And she's the best at what she does."

Once more he looked at Glimmer, who only shrugged, then to Catra, who nodded him on, somewhat impatiently. Micah rapped gently on the door and called, "Mortella?"

As if on cue, the door swung open into a candlelit study, just as dim and filled with books as the rest of the library. From somewhere within, a smoky voice responded, "Come in, friends. I don't bite."

Micah stepped into the study with surprising ease, then motioned back to Catra and Glimmer to follow him. Glimmer entered without much thought—it wasn't any creepier than anything else down here, she thought. But when she turned back to close the door, Catra still hadn't followed.

"What's wrong?" Glimmer whispered.

Catra's eyes darted around the room. "Nothing. I just thought … Nothing." She shook her head and closed her eyes, then followed Glimmer in.

Glimmer took in Mortella's office: the low masonry ceilings, the candles carefully placed away from any of the bookshelves, the utter lack of anything resembling a desk. There were five chairs surrounding a circular wooden table in the center of the room, into which was carved a pentacle, though it was mostly concealed by stacks of papers and crystals. Curiously, Glimmer did not immediately spot Mortella herself—until she appeared behind one of the chairs out of a shadowy corner.

She was tall—much taller than Micah, though that wasn't hard—with dark skin and darker hair, tied back in a purple scarf. Her robes were almost all black, save for some purple and red embroidery at the cuffs and collar. Her sleeves hung down like bat wings as she opened her arms in a welcoming gesture.

"Micah. It's wonderful to see you again," she said with a gentle smile. Micah awkwardly side-stepped around the table to give her a friendly hug, then retreated to the side of his daughter. "And this must be your daughter, hm? Her Majesty the Queen?"

Glimmer took a slight bow but kept eye contact with Mortella, noticing how her dark irises reflected the candlelight like perfect mirrors.

"Pleasure to meet you, Professor," Glimmer said, her voice still distant as she took in her surroundings.

Mortella chuckled. “Please, Your Majesty. No need for that. You can call me Mortella.” She turned to Catra with an eyebrow cocked. “And you must be the young hotshot foreign minister, yes? Catra? I have to admit your reputation precedes you a little.”

In the dim light, Glimmer could just barely see Catra’s cheeks darken at that. “Oh. Uh. Yeah.” She looked away, accidentally catching Glimmer’s eyes for a moment, and rubbed her neck in embarrassment. “I’ve done a lot since the war. I’m a different person now.”

She didn’t sound very sure of it.

“Oh, I wasn’t talking about the war, silly,” Mortella said flippantly. She pulled out the tallest chair and took a seat, then picked up a steaming mug of tea that Glimmer had failed to notice. “I just meant … you know. You and She-Ra. Bright Moon’s power couple.”

Catra’s eyes went wide and it didn’t look like she had any way to respond to that, so Glimmer came to her aid. “She’s the most dedicated civil servant the kingdom has. I never travel without her.”

Mortella’s eyebrows twitched upward momentarily. “I wouldn’t either. Please, sit down, Your Majesties. Tell me about your situation.”

Catra’s blush darkened. She backed away from the table, apparently believing the invitation had not been meant for her, and began inspecting the shelf. Glimmer and Micah each took seats at the seance table.

“I’ll try to be brief,” Micah started with a sigh. “Essentially, for the past few weeks, both Glimmer and I have been unable to cast spells of any kind. I can still feel the magic around me, I can still concentrate and visualize and all that, but nothing comes out.”

Glimmer took his pause as an opportunity to introduce her position. “Casta seemed to think that it had something to do with

Sh—" she cut herself off as her wandering eyes landed on Catra, standing at a bookshelf with one ear pointed toward the table. "The person who trained us, and her … particular way of doing things. But I wanted to explore some other possibilities."

"Oh?" Mortella prompted, and Glimmer continued.

"Well, one time I got cursed." *By the same person who ended up teaching me,* Glimmer thought but didn't say. Her spine still shivered to think of the surging red tide of pure pain through her body. "I couldn't use my elemental powers for days after that, and I was never really clear on how I broke it. So I was wondering if maybe we'd been cursed."

Mortella hummed. "Have you been noticing any other strange occurrences? Curses usually come with side effects. Visual or aural hallucinations, sudden intense pain, waves of terror or dread, weird bugs, anything like that?"

"Bugs?" asked Glimmer.

Mortella nodded. "Sometimes there are bugs."

Glimmer thought for a moment. Definitely no bugs, and she would probably remember having hallucinations or phantom pains. She got panic attacks sometimes, but hey, didn't everybody?

As she considered this, Glimmer's eyes scanned the room absently until once again, inevitably, they found Catra. Only this time, she wasn't pacing or feigning polite distraction as she browsed. She was frozen still, staring at the closed door with eyes wide as if realizing something.

While Glimmer watched Catra, the conversation continued without her.

"But there's still the issue of who would do such a thing," said Micah. "I can't think of anyone alive on Etheria that would have the will, the access, or the sheer magical power it would take to stop us from conjuring completely."

“Well,” Mortella said slowly, “There are things other than traditional curses. There are cursed artifacts, magical boobytraps, things like that. Or maybe some deity somewhere has become angry with you for some reason.”

Glimmer saw Catra’s brows push together in thought.

Mortella continued, “Or … some other being not of this world. A demon. Maybe a ghost.”

This yanked Glimmer’s attention back to the conversation. She spun back around in her chair. “A *ghost?* Ghosts are real?”

“As real as any other idea that we allow to have power. Only in this case it’s a memory of someone which takes on substance.”

As Glimmer stared at her, slack-jawed, there was the sound of a door opening and closing. Mortella’s face twisted with confusion.

She pointed at the door. “Did she have somewhere to be?”

Glimmer turned around to where Catra had stood only a moment ago, and saw nothing. Her heart raced. Without a second thought, she drew the Moonstone’s light into her body and blinked out of the room.

Chapter End Notes

Illustration by EmileeDoodles! Go check out her stuff!

You guys feeling spooked yet?

to conjure up a ghost

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

Glimmer flashed to the top of the staircase on the next floor up of the library. She hid herself around the corner momentarily, and soon enough, she heard the telltale *pat pat pat* of Catra's bare feet running up the stairs. She spun around the corner just in time for Catra to leap up the last few stairs and onto the dimly lit landing, held out both arms, meaning to catch Catra in an arresting embrace—but she was too slow. Catra darted to one side and slipped out of her grasp all too easily.

"Don't follow me, Sparkles," Catra shouted over her shoulder as she rounded the corner onto the next staircase. "I'm leaving and you're not stopping me."

"Catra!" she called back. Glimmer blinked to the next landing, this time too close for Catra to evade her. She wrapped her arms around Catra's struggling form. "Come on, calm down!" she grunted. "You haven't even told me— *ugh* —what's going on."

Catra only growled, then managed to wriggle underneath Glimmer's arms and past her, knocking her over in the process. Glimmer hit the floor with a grunt.

She sighed. If she couldn't match Catra with speed or strength, then she would have to outsmart her. Again, she closed her eyes, gathered the Moonstone's magic, and willed herself into Catra's guest room.

She didn't have to wait long. After only a minute or two of standing pressed to the wall next to the door, it swung open and Catra stormed in, huffing and out of breath. She didn't notice Glimmer at first, just commenced frantically throwing her belongings into her suitcase. It was easy enough for Glimmer to side-step until she blocked the door entirely.

Catra still didn't notice, too preoccupied with her escape attempt, so Glimmer cleared her throat, loud and petulant. That did the trick. Catra's ear turned to Glimmer, then the rest of her.

Glimmer had a *You really thought it was going to be that easy?* prepared, but she was taken aback by Catra's expression. Her face was not one of frustration or anger as Glimmer had expected, but rather of fear. Fear and desperation.

"I don't have time for this, Glimmer," she growled. "I need to leave, now."

"Catra," Glimmer said, trying to sound gentle but maybe just sounding pathetic, "just tell me what's going on. Is there some kind of emergency?"

Catra put her head in her hands, then looked back at Glimmer with some terrible truth in her eyes. "I'm the emergency, Glimmer. I'm what's fucking everything up."

"What do you mean?"

"I don't really know how to explain this but…" Catra paused, closed her eyes and balled her fists at her sides. "Weird stuff has been happening to me, okay? The kind of weird stuff that Mortella was talking about. And I think … I think it's Shadow Weaver. I think she did something to me."

Glimmer approached her cautiously. "How?"

"It's the only thing that makes sense. Adora and I were the last people she saw before she died. She must have done something to me, something weird, and whatever it is must be messing everything up and stopping you and Micah from doing magic."

Finally, Glimmer was within reach of her, so she touched Catra's arm as tenderly as she could. Nothing Catra said really made any sense, but Glimmer had to be gentle about telling her.

“Whatever is happening to you,” Glimmer said softly, “we can figure it out, okay? We just need to stay together.”

With a hesitant almost-smile, Catra returned the gesture and placed her hand on Glimmer’s side—the same side where Glimmer still felt the wound from the night before. It happened too quickly for her to suppress a wince of pain. It was brief—the pain disappeared after only a second. It couldn’t have been long enough for Catra to have noticed.

Still, any trace of a smile was gone from Catra’s face as she pulled her hand back. She looked entirely closed off, arms wrapped around herself like there could be no other comfort in the world. Glimmer opened her mouth to say something, anything at all that had even the slightest chance of bridging the distance again—but before any words could get out, a knock came at the door.

“Glimmer?” Micah’s voice called from the hall. “Are you in there? Is everything okay?”

She closed her eyes, took a deep breath, and steeled herself to talk to her father. Glimmer slipped out into the hallway.

The look on Micah’s face was one of appreciable concern. Glimmer felt genuinely bad that he couldn’t possibly understand the depth of what had been happening between her and Catra.

“Everything is fine, Dad. Let’s just leave her alone and go finish up at the library.” She barely looked into his eyes as she said it, and turned to walk away just as soon as she finished.

He didn’t follow. Glimmer walked a few paces down the hallway, staring up at the arches in the ceiling, but Micah’s footsteps didn’t echo behind her. She stopped and looked over her shoulder.

“There’s nothing else to do in the library,” he said grimly. His face had fallen back into the same disappointed grimace Glimmer had grown accustomed to seeing whenever he tried to connect with her.

She shook her head. “There has to be something—”

“Can you please just tell me what’s going with you, Glimmer? With Catra?” he pleaded quietly. His voice reverberated down the hallway like a prayer in a cathedral.

Glimmer became suddenly exasperated. “Nothing is going on between us, Dad. Catra is dealing with her stuff and I’m dealing with mine.”

“Then how come none of us can ever be honest with one another?” He approached Glimmer slowly, drifting toward her like an iceberg. “There’s something between you and Catra, and there’s something between you and me too, but I can’t get through it. It’s like there’s a wall. Why?”

She could feel the words almost exploding from her throat. *Because we don’t know each other! What would I do if I let you know me, let you* love *me, and then I lost you again?*

But that wasn’t what came from between her lips. The next thing she said, her last words before returning to the library to continue searching for an answer without the help of her father, were these:

“I don’t know what you’re talking about, Micah.”

Many things in **Catra** ’s life had been decided for her in the past. She had liked to think she had a choice the whole time—when she was younger she had told herself, told everyone that she liked being second-best. To admit that someone other than herself had a say in her life was to admit vulnerability, weakness, defeat. So she had said the same when she let Adora leave the Horde without her—that it was a choice. To rise up the ranks, to nearly conquer all of Etheria. To ignore the pain in her chest every time she had seen Adora. But these were not choices, not really. These were the only paths forward that had allowed her to protect herself.

But ever since she had gained the ability to make *real* choices, Catra liked to think she had made good ones. Ones that put other people first, that acknowledged the reality that people must rely on each other. Saving Glimmer, and by extension Adora, had been her first. Now, she was presented with another such choice.

Catra had hurt— *was hurting* Glimmer. The curse was on her. It was the only explanation that made sense. Not just that, but she had hurt Glimmer *physically* too—lashed out during her nightmare (was it a nightmare?) and cut a gash in the queen's side. Glimmer wouldn't do anything about it. She preferred to keep living in her pretty pink princess castle where nothing could ever hurt her. But that was fine. Glimmer didn't need to do anything except not interfere.

Catra could solve this problem easily. *Pack your bags and leave right now.* If she bore the curse, and the curse was hurting the people she cared about, then she should remove herself from the equation. *Run back to Bright Moon and hide with Adora just like you used to. Resign from your office. Stay in your room all the time like the caged animal you are.*

Her mini-pad buzzed in her pocket with a message—probably Adora asking if she was okay, she figured, if the roiling storm in her mind was enough to reach across the empathic link she shared with Melog. But she couldn't keep the squall at bay long enough to check.

Thoughts spiraled and swarmed in her head like locusts. The sound of their logic was inescapable, an ever-present whisper that permeated every quiet corner of her mind. It was too loud. It coalesced and took form, took on a voice of its own.

"Do the right thing, Catra."

It was in her head, she knew it. Still, she looked around the guest room, searching for something moving in the long evening shadows on the floor.

"You can solve all their problems."

It was even louder this time, even clearer than the voice from the other night. Even more *her.*

"You've grown so much, child. But you can't change your stripes. It's better if you go."

Catra couldn't help the hiss that escaped her teeth as she hunched up her shoulders and unsheathed her claws. "Show yourself. I'm not afraid of you."

The sorceress still didn't take shape. But the shadows on the floor began to twitch, their edges becoming liquid like tongues of flame. The voice returned.

"You don't have any reason to be afraid, Catra. I can't hurt you and you don't want to hurt me."

A chill ran all over Catra's skin, causing the fine hair all over her to stand on end and her tail to begin thrashing wildly. The chill became a concentrated freeze on her shoulder and she instinctively flinched away, swatting at the air with her claws.



"People like us simply can't live with people like them," the voice said, almost directly into Catra's right ear. *"We're too broken. We're covered in jagged edges."*

"What happened to you being proud of me?" Catra whispered to the thing she knew was behind her, though she still couldn't see it.

The voice assumed a sickening saccharine quality that had once been reserved only for Adora. *"Of course I'm proud of you, Catra. Proud of how far you've come and how much you've accomplished. But that doesn't change what you are. They'd never understand it. But I do."*

Catra growled and backed herself slowly toward the door. The shadows on the floor danced like boiling water.

"I'm only trying to help you, Catra."

"So you cursed me? How is that helping?" she said, in what she hoped would be a distraction while she reached for the doorknob behind her back.

Shadow Weaver—or whatever was left of her—chuckled darkly. *"Please. A curse? What kind of petty witch do you take me for? Do you think I want to be here any more than you do?"*

Catra twisted the door open and stumbled backward as quickly as she could, slamming it behind her. She only caught a glimpse of the shadows creeping under the door before launching herself down the hallway on all fours.

Catra ran, ran, ran until the air stung her throat. She didn't know where she was going—only knew that no matter how many turns she took, no matter what secluded cloister she found herself in, the shadows and the whispers were always right behind, always

just about to catch her. The oily slick of Shadow Weaver's magic embedded itself between her toes, in her hair, under her skin, just as if it had never left.

She swung around another turn and into a wider corridor, seeing ahead but not really looking—all her attention still turned to the creeping darkness at her back. Her claws tapped a frantic rhythm on the stone floor. The stale air rushed through her hair.

It all came to a stop suddenly—her body, the noise, the wind, and the shadows—as Catra slammed into a warm body. She didn't look to see who it was, but they were just a little taller than her, broad-shouldered, and warm. Close enough. She threw her arms around them, buried her head in the crook of their neck, and sobbed.

"Help," she managed, her voice low and scratchy. "Chasing me … Can't get away."

"Catra?"

The voice that answered was deep and sonorous—familiar, but not who she had thought it would be in her panic. This was when Catra noticed the stubble at the edge of a beard that ended on her protector's neck. She slowly peeled herself away and found, yes, King Micah. His arms surrounded her without hesitation and his face was tight with concern, a little fear, and what Catra thought could be a kind of understanding.

"What happened? Are you alright?" he asked quietly, as if he were trying to hide himself.

"I—I…" she stuttered, still gasping for air. Her instincts were screaming at her to *run, hide, there's safety in solitude.* But Shadow Weaver's voice was there too, mixed in with her own in a dissonant harmony. *It's better if you go.*

And when had listening to Shadow Weaver done anything except fuck her up?

“It was Shadow Weaver. She’s … here, somehow,” Catra explained. Her voice evened out slowly as she did so. “She spoke to me and she made the shadows move. In my room.”

Micah’s face twisted with confusion, then horror as he listened. “That’s… That shouldn’t be possible. Are you sure it was her?”

Catra nodded unshakingly. There was nothing else in the universe that could make her nerves crawl like the feeling of Shadow Weaver’s dark magic in the room.

“That sounds like…” Micah looked down the hallway and hummed in thought, then looked back at Catra. “When I was on Beast Island, after Shadow Weaver banished me there, I had something similar. But that was because of the degraded First Ones signal. You haven’t had any ringing in your ears, have you?”

“Not that I remember, no.”

He looked at her more deeply then, searching for something in her eyes, and seemed to find it. Then he pulled her back into his embrace. Once again, the back of Catra’s mind revolted and demanded that she push him away. Her body froze up at the contact, her ears folding back and tail thrashing. But she fought the impulse off with a feeling that she hadn’t expected, but welcomed: safety. Micah made her feel safe. It could simply have been the way he was shaped—broad and muscular, his form bore a passing resemblance to the one Catra curled up next to every night. But it was a different kind of safety. Adora was safe like a home, Glimmer was safe like a hiding place, but Micah was safe like … something Catra had never had a word for before. Someone who knew the world more than she, who knew where she came from and had watched her grow, who could always stand behind her and catch her when she fell.

A father, she might have said, if that word had meant more to her.

Chapter End Notes

someone call the fucking ghost busters

Illustration by EmileeDoodles

up they come, gone translucent

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

To her chagrin, Micah had been right: there was little else to discuss with Mortella when **Glimmer** returned to the library without her father. Glimmer told her that Catra suspected she had been cursed, and that it was somehow affecting Glimmer and Micah too. Mortella cast some doubt on that possibility. "Death curses—wherein the caster expends the last of their life force—tend to be concentrated on the person, place, or object which the caster targeted," she had said. Then she told Glimmer to keep an eye on Catra and see if anything else developed.

But keeping an eye on Catra would have been like keeping an eye on a dam that was about to break.

So instead, she paced the stacks of the library basement outside Mortella's office, looking for any arcane volume that might have clued her in to what was blocking her access to Etheria's magic. It was hard to see some of the titles down there in the dark, especially with many of the leather spines so cracked and faded after countless years of use. The books all blended together into a brackish-brown bar interrupted with spots of darkened greens, reds, and blues. Glimmer's eyes skimmed over the titles, hoping the right one would simply jump out at her, flag her down with bright colors and clear lettering and say, *Here I am! The solution to all your problems.*

The violet-bound book that her eyes did fall upon did not match that title exactly. But it did look to be several hundred years newer than its neighbors on the shelf, so Glimmer took a closer look.

The title read, in baroque silver lettering, *Taboo: Dark Magic and the Forbidden Final Frontier.*

And the author's name, in equally bold type: *L. Spinner.*

There must have been some other L. Spinner, Glimmer figured. Surely the library wouldn't have kept a book by the former commander of the Horde, let alone the most wicked sorceress to ever walk the halls of Mystacor. Still, a terrible sense of dread took root in Glimmer's stomach as her hand moved almost automatically to slide the book out of its place.

The volume fell open in Glimmer's palm to somewhere in the middle of the introductory chapter, where she guessed most people probably stopped reading. Glimmer had never been one to stop at such a warning, though.

She summoned an orb of light from the Moonstone and commenced reading from the top of the page, muttering under her breath. "'Opponents tend to focus on the extremes of dark magic, and the dangers it poses to both the caster and others. What this book intends to do is not to negate all those points: there is certainly something to be said about the way dark magic can take hold of its users, the way it can overrun a caster's ability and spread to everything it touches, like a wildfire. But those things have been said countless times already. Rather, this work will focus on the uses of dark magic in moderation, and how it can expand the horizons of any sorcerer with enough discipline to control it.'"

Glimmer snapped the book shut with a dismissive hiss through her teeth. "Yeah, right."

She went to slide it back into its place, but found that the books around it seemed to have pushed themselves together, collapsing the space where Light Spinner's book stood just a moment ago. The dark band of leather on the shelf was once again uninterrupted by the purple streak Glimmer held in her hand, and it seemed to want to stay that way, somehow.

As Glimmer stared at the etching on the cover of the volume, something moved in the corner of her eye. She turned, growing her orb of elemental light into something more substantial on a defensive instinct, but found nothing in the shadows it illuminated.

Then, a whisper came from the other side of the basement—Glimmer couldn't make out what it said—and then another movement, this time at the end of the shelves she stood between. A chill permeated her spine, which in turn caused the gash in her side to throb.

Slowly, brandishing Light Spinner's book as a bludgeon should it become necessary, Glimmer treaded to the end of the shelves. She paused, pressed herself against one wall of books, then peeked her head around to find—

Nothing, again.

Glimmer exhaled, but the tension didn't leave her body. She turned back to the stacks to return the book.

There, at the other end of the corridor, a face hung in midair. No, not a face—a mask. White eyes suspended in a black void, dark red like congealed blood around a crack down its center.

 Shadow Weaver's mask, suspended in shadow.

All at once, Glimmer screamed, surrounded herself with the Moonstone's light, and disappeared.

Glimmer reappeared in Catra's guest room, still screaming. Naturally, this startled Catra, who in turn jumped up from where she had been sitting on the bed next to—surprisingly—Micah. He then sprung upward as well, shouting Glimmer's name and rushing to her side.

"What happened?" he asked, both hands on her shoulders as he examined her face.

She struggled to slow her breathing, clutching Light Spinner's inauspicious book to her chest with both arms. After a moment of grounding herself with the sensation of her father's hands, she managed to reply, "I saw … something. In the library. A mask. Like … like Shadow Weaver's."

Micah's lips formed a tense line. He shut his eyes.

"Am I crazy?" Glimmer pleaded. "Please tell me I'm not crazy."

"Not this time, Sparkles," Catra said. She sat on the bed again with her hands balled into fists in her lap. There was an awful sort of honesty in her voice that Glimmer had only heard a few times before. "She was here, too. She spoke to me."

"I can't explain any of this," said Micah gruffly. "She shouldn't be able to manifest like this. She's dead. She is dead, right?" He glanced at Catra.

Catra nodded. "Dead as fuck."

"One of us needs to go get Mortella."

"I still have my Moonstone powers," Glimmer said, trying to sound helpful. "I can pop down there and— *ah,"* pain radiated from her side, knocking the wind out of her lungs and nearly doubling her over. She dropped the book.

"Glimmer, what's wrong?" Micah gasped. He held a hand over her own on the place where Catra had cut her. "Are you hurt?"

Glimmer caught Catra's eyes, sunken and narrowed, close to tears. As Catra looked away, her tail snaked around her torso and her ears folded back

"It was me," Catra muttered, "wasn't it?"

Glimmer sighed. She supposed there was no use trying to hide it anymore. "Yeah. When you had your nightmare last night."

"Fuck. I can't believe myself," Catra grunted. She held her head in her hands.

And then, something unexpected: Micah took his hands off Glimmer and walked over to Catra, kneeled down in front of her, wrapped his hands around her wrists, and comforted *her.*

"Hey, it's alright. It was an accident," Micah whispered as he gently pulled Catra's hands away from her face. The scene filled Glimmer with a surprising warmth. Micah had tried to be a father to her on many instances since the end of the war and most of the time, Glimmer had refused it. But seeing the way Catra looked at him then, smiling at him so gratefully, it stoked a kind of longing in Glimmer's heart that she had tried for too long to ignore.

"I'll go get Mortella and some first aid supplies, okay?" Micah said, looking from Catra to Glimmer. Catra nodded, a nervous, hopeful gesture, then Micah stood and approached Glimmer again.

She expected a friendly pat on the shoulder, but what she got was a hug. Micah opened his arms wide and wrapped Glimmer up in them, bundling her like a child. He kissed the crown of her head.

"I'll be right back, babygirl," he whispered into her hair. Micah released Glimmer from his embrace and looked into her eyes. The deep brown of his irises held a kind of understanding that only Bow had given her before. "You two should talk."

He glanced back at Catra, then at Glimmer, who tried to look confused as to what he meant. But she could tell by the cock of his salt-and-pepper eyebrow that she couldn't hide it from him either.

Glimmer exhaled. "Okay."

Micah smiled at her, then slipped behind her and out the door before anything else could be said.

Once again, Glimmer was alone with Catra. But this felt different, Glimmer thought. Previously there had always been something left unacknowledged between them. Even that night in the garden when Glimmer had let loose, she hadn't said everything she had meant to. Neither had Catra. That's what the kiss had been for, Glimmer reasoned. It hadn't been some overworked, frenzied surrender to her basest desires. Or it hadn't *just* been that, at

least. It had been a substitute for all the ugly feelings neither of them wanted to give voice to: nostalgia, grief, resentment, guilt.

Those were the things Glimmer didn't want to carry alone anymore.

"Can I make some tea?" Glimmer offered as a start. Catra's ears perked up, but the rest of her stayed shrunken.

Glimmer took the silence as an affirmative and headed for the pre-stocked tea nook, carefully holding her hand over the wound in her side so she didn't pull at it. It was slow going, enough that Catra had time to get up and stop her.

"Let me do it, Sparkles," she said. She guided Glimmer over to sit in her spot on the bed. It was still warm. "You take it easy."

Glimmer smiled gratefully at Catra, but got nothing in return. Catra's face remained a mask of guilt, lines carved into her forehead like a marble statue, as she left Glimmer on the bed to make the tea.

A memory floated to the top of Glimmer's mind: the first time she had tried darjeeling tea. It was the same story she had remembered that morning in Bright Moon, the morning before the kiss in the garden. Only this time, another detail came back to her: she had been hurt. She had been practicing teleporting, just a spry little princess excited to finally come into her own and join the war effort, when she'd miscalculated and used up all the Moonstone's light before landing safely. She had come tumbling down from a tree on the terrace, scraped her knees and bruised her ribs. Her mother had tended to her wounds and gave her the most delicious cup of tea she'd ever had, telling her, *"It was just an accident. Accidents are how you learn, my love. There's no need to be embarrassed. It'll be our little secret—like the Goddess and her tea."*

The simile had been tenuous at best. After all, the Goddess hadn't been very good at keeping her precious tea a secret. Maybe she

had been foolish for trying to hide it in the first place, if in its revealing, it had only ended up making the world a better place.

Then maybe the metaphor *did* make sense. Maybe Glimmer's pain, her weakness, was something to be shared—no matter how bitter it tasted.

Catra returned to her side then, bearing a steaming cup of something floral in a souvenir mug printed with the Sorcerers Guild's coat of arms.

"Here," she said, and Glimmer cradled the tea carefully in both hands. "It's camo … something."

Glimmer chuckled. "Chamomile."

"Sure," Catra said with a dismissive hand-wave. The same hand then landed on Glimmer's lap, feather-light, claws carefully retracted. "Listen, I'm … I'm really sorry I scratched you last night. That hasn't happened in a really long time and I just feel so stupid about it."

"It's okay," said Glimmer after a sip of tea. She patted Catra's hand, trying her best to sound reassuring despite the pain tightening its grip. "It's nothing, really. I suffered plenty worse during the war."

Catra scoffed, not unkindly. "Sparkles, we both know my claws can cut through steel if I want them to. Whatever it is, it's not nothing."

Glimmer sighed and set the mug down on the bed stand. *Share the tea.*

"Okay, yeah," she admitted, "it's pretty bad. But I promise it's not a big deal, okay? It was an accident."

Catra's face fell. "Can I see?"

“Oh.” Glimmer had been ready to admit that it hurt—she was far from ready to show Catra the wound. She hadn’t even looked at it herself since that morning; it might have been uglier than either of them could stomach.

“You don’t have to,” Catra said, backpedaling, “I just wanted to … make sure you’re okay.”

Just that touch of softness was enough to convince Glimmer. She untucked the hem of her top and lifted it carefully up on the left side, conscious of how fragile it felt, to show Catra.

Catra blushed as Glimmer lifted her top, which was how she remembered that she hadn’t bothered to put on a bra that morning, but they were both just going to have to live with that.

“Oh,” Catra said under her breath, her ears falling again. “Shit. Damn it.”

“Hey, it’s fine,” said Glimmer. She hid the wound again. “My dad’s coming back with first aid.”

Catra squeezed her eyes shut. “It’s not that, it’s … how many more times do I have to fuck up and hurt someone before I learn how to control myself?”

“Catra—”

“How many more accidents do I need to have? How many more times where I lash out and lose a friend? How much do I have to endure before I finally learn how to be a good person?”

“You are a good person, Catra,” Glimmer said in what she hoped was a firm tone. “And you didn’t get that way by enduring pain. You’re here because you freed yourself from the people who were hurting you, and you grew.”

“But I was bad, wasn’t I?” Catra jabbed back, looking Glimmer in the eyes. Glimmer parted her lips to reply, but found she had nothing to say. “I was a bad person. I did bad things. And I had to

learn a lot of hard lessons to get to where I am now. I had to be humbled. I had to…" she trailed off, her eyes going distant with the horror of a realization, "to suffer."

Catra reached for the back of her neck, where Glimmer knew a scar still marked her as a survivor of Horde Prime. Catra's breathing became shallow, her eyes glassy, and before Glimmer knew it she was crying—noiselessly. No sobs racked her body, but tears spilled down her face nonetheless. The hand that didn't grip her neck now held her thigh in a steel-crushing vice

At once, Glimmer reached for Catra's wrists, tried to pry her hands away from her skin. When that failed, she settled for running her thumb along Catra's knuckles and whispering, "Hey, hey, Catra. I'm here. You're here. We're okay."

Catra looked at her, still crying, but present—not falling.

"Catra," Glimmer said slowly, making sure Catra could understand her before continuing, "you didn't need to suffer. This is what I meant that night, when I asked if you thought you deserved what Prime did to you. You didn't. You survived it, and you became a better person afterward, but those things aren't related. In fact, you probably would've gotten better a lot faster if you hadn't been hurt as much."

"Huh," said Catra, and chuckled. Glimmer found herself laughing dryly too, at the irony of it all. All the pain they'd both endured, all the losses they'd suffered—they were just that: pain and loss, no silver linings.

Chapter End Notes

illustration by EmileeDoodles

interlude

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

That realization, the meaninglessness of suffering, the inertia of it knocked them down. It left them feeling like nothing but an amalgam of feelings, instincts and reactions. **Glimmer** and **Catra** sat on a bed in Mystacor together, hiding from a ghost from their shared past and hoping it wouldn't kill them before they got a shot at the future—the happily ever after that had never seemed to come.

There was a knock on the door that startled them both, before they remembered that Micah had gone to retrieve supplies and expertise in the form of Mortella. The day-moons had long since set, and nightfall had a funny way of making them forget what had happened during the day.

"Come in," called Glimmer, and the door swung open with surprising haste.

Micah rushed into the room holding a troublingly large red chest, and Mortella in tow. "Sorry it took us so long," he explained, huffing as he set the first aid box down. "This thing is a lot heavier than it looks." He opened the chest and commenced rummaging through it, resurfacing from his dive with cotton gauze, a bottle of potion, and a roll of cloth bandage.

Catra felt a tug of urgency as Micah knelt in front of his daughter with the supplies. She held out a hand and stopped him before he could ask to see the wound.

"Can I do it, actually?" Catra asked, taking Glimmer quite off guard.

Glimmer stared at her questioningly, and Catra replied with a shrug, "Horde first aid training was really good." It was doubtful

that Glimmer believed this obvious lie, but she didn't object.

"Sure," Glimmer replied quickly, and just as quickly her father handed the supplies to Catra, who motioned for Glimmer to lift up her top again. She obliged cautiously.

Catra's hands, claws retracted, were soft and careful as she dabbed Glimmer's side with a potion-wet piece of gauze. It stung a little as the potion worked, and Glimmer sucked a breath through her teeth, which gave Catra pause. They exchanged a startlingly intimate look. Both blushed, then averted their eyes as Catra set to work again.

"So," said the looming Mortella, "tell me what you all experienced." She steepled her fingers, posing like one of the statues in the Hall of Sorcerers.

Catra kept her gaze fixed on her hands as she patched Glimmer up. As distantly as she could manage, she explained, "I've been seeing weird shadows this whole time, like … things slithering and undulating and stuff. The other night I had what I thought was a nightmare, where I saw them in the corner and they had eyes like Shadow Weaver's mask, and she was whispering something repetitive. And then today it happened again, but we…" she paused and gulped, then continued, "she spoke directly to me, and I talked back. And the shadows were … grabbing at me."

Glimmer shivered, both under the chilling memory of her vision in the library, and under Catra's touch as she wrapped a bandage over the wound, securing it around Glimmer's waist.

"I saw something too," Glimmer said quietly. "Shadow Weaver's mask, in the library. And I felt cold."

"I tend not to lend much credibility to things that could be hallucinations, but … I think I've seen and heard some things too," Micah supplied.

Mortella hummed, and her dark eyes landed on the floor. "What's this?" she muttered, bending down, and came back up with the

copy of Light Spinner's *Taboo* that Glimmer had previously abandoned on the floor. She turned it over in her hands like a puzzle.

"Oh," Glimmer sighed, ashamed, "that. I found it in the library before I saw the mask. I think it might have been in the wrong section … ?"

"Your Majesty," Mortella said with an ominous chuckle, "nothing in the Norwyn Library is ever in the wrong section. It arranges itself precisely as it means to."

Catra released Glimmer's top suddenly and said, "Wait, the library is *alive?!"*

"Enchanted, Minister Catra, not alive. No need to anthropomorphize."

"Still." She shivered.

"Anyway," Mortella continued, "these are no doubt manifestations of Shadow Weaver's dark magic, so this book may come in handy."

Micah scratched his beard. "But how are they manifesting if she's not around to control them? No intention, no magic, that's how it works."

The occultist absently flipped through several pages of Light Spinner's book and hummed in thought. "I believe these happenings are being caused by the imprints of Shadow Weaver's intentions as they were in life. They are an echo of her." She smiled wryly. "A shadow, if you will."

"A ghost?" Glimmer said, almost whispering in horror.

"Not quite. It's something more powerful than that." Mortella tucked the book under her arm and began walking around the room, almost floating in her umbral gowns, subtly drawing circles of dark blue light in the air near the windows and doors. She

tapped Micah, Glimmer, and Catra's shoulders as she passed each. "All magic leaves traces on those who use it and the people, places, and things it touches, even after a spell's effects wear off. But dark magic is especially … *sticky.* You all have surely noticed that in the past, haven't you?"

Catra flinched at the sudden emergence of a memory, or rather a lifetime of memories. Every time that old hag had restrained her, shocked her, touched her with shadows at all, Catra's muscles had twinged and ached for days after. Adora used to hold her tight in the bunk as she writhed in discomfort all night, no matter how hard she tried to sleep.

Glimmer, too, recalled the awful crawling of her skin that had stayed long after Shadow Weaver's curse had worn off, and had only continued once she became a pupil of the sorceress. Her breath caught in her throat.

Mortella watched with half-curious, half-sympathetic eyes as Micah began thinking out loud. "If we all carry remnants of Shadow Weaver's magic—and surely Mystacor itself carries remnants of it, too—then with all of us gathered together, in this place…"

"… You form a nexus," Mortella finished. "With enough of her magical echo concentrated in one place and time, it takes on substance. It becomes something more."

All at once, Catra felt that familiar twinge in her muscles return. It came back with a terrible, quiet thought: *You should have left when you had the chance. All of this happened because you three were together.*

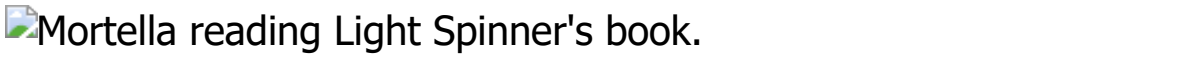
"So I was right," Catra whispered, and Glimmer placed a firm hand on her thigh.

"It's not your fault, Catra," the queen commanded quietly, "you didn't know. None of us did. Please stay."

Then, Mortella was standing in front of them, looking down with sad, knowing eyes. “I’m afraid there wouldn’t be any use in running now, my dear. Once it’s formed, there’s no going back. It’s cyclical, a magical feedback loop. It will follow all three of you wherever you go, feeding off of Shadow Weaver’s influence. You can try to live with it, but it may destroy you. I suggest you break the cycle now.”

“Please, Mortella,” said Micah, a hand on her shoulder, “tell us what we need to do.”

She smiled, then opened Light Spinner’s book again, this time to a page somewhere in the middle covered in diagrams and instructions.

 Mortella reading Light Spinner's book.

“Think of this manifestation as a stain,” she explained, quite teacher-like. “What do you use to remove a stain?”

“… Soap?” Catra offered.

“Soap, bleach, baking soda, whatever you have. A cleanser.” Mortella lowered the edge of the book, offering the page for all to see. “This is a very powerful cleansing spell. A banishment spell, to be exact. It requires three casters with a connection to the spirit working in tandem.”

“Okay, problem,” said Glimmer, raising a hand as if she were in a classroom, “Dad and I still can’t cast.”

“And I can’t do magic at all,” Catra added.

Micah hummed and stroked his beard. “I don’t think that will be an issue. This spell is a ritual.”

“Very clever, Micah,” said Mortella. She poked the tip of his nose affectionately. “You always were. More powerful, dark-tinged spells, like the one Light Spinner so graciously outlined for us here, are often cast as rituals, sacrificing speed and tidiness for

dramatic increases in power and efficacy. Such a ritual relies on ingredients and incantations rather than the conjuration that sorcerers typically practice. I'll be happy to gather materials for you while you prepare." The book snapped closed, and Mortella's face became severe, as did her voice when she gave a final instruction:

"In order for this spell to work as intended, you must all three be completely open to one another. Your energies must intermingle freely, otherwise you risk retaining traces of Shadow Weaver's spirit. Begin preparing immediately. Leave nothing unspoken among you."

With that, Mortella smiled and headed for the door. "I'll be back in an hour with the ingredients. I left some temporary wards on the doors and windows, and in the hallway. Cheers!"

The door shut, a few sparks of dark blue flying off of it as Mortella exited, and then Micah, Glimmer, and Catra were alone together. They exchanged worried looks.

"Well," said Micah, clasping his hands together, "let's begin."

Chapter End Notes

illustration by EmileeDoodles

a place where there's water

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

Despite **Glimmer** 's convictions that it should never happen, she now sat in a locked room with her father, about to blow the dam that barely held back twenty-one years' worth of feelings about him, among many other painful, embarrassing things. There was no navigating this. It would sweep her away, drown her, she was sure of it. Where could she start? *Hi, Dad, I'm your daughter and I can't be close with you because I'm still not convinced that you're really here?*

And if she didn't, if she continued her self-preservatory avoidance, an evil shadow spirit would haunt the two of them, plus Catra, for the rest of their lives, and she may never cast a spell again.

Cool.

Catra , in her own way, was caught on a cliff, a raging wildfire at her back and an endless drop into an abyssal sea below her. Should she stay the way she had always been—distant, alone, just her and her claws and her bad habits against the world—she would surely burn up. But should she take the plunge, face her fears and let a flood of vulnerability sweep her away, who knows what she would find? She couldn't hold her breath forever.

Glimmer wanted Catra around, wanted Catra to trust her with her heart, dive in so Glimmer could pull her to safety. But it was never going to be that simple. Catra was supposed to make Glimmer's life easier. Glimmer was the queen, and Catra was just one of her many ministers, allies, advisors, and friends. She was just trying to be useful, to make this woman's life that little bit easier after doing her best to ruin it for three years. She knew what happened when Glimmer tried to help her: Glimmer got hurt. Was there any

way Catra could be near her, when her claws were the only way she could reach out?

And Micah… She still didn't know what to think about him, what name she could put to the way he made her feel. She felt understood, but in a way that almost made her sad, a cocktail of pity and sympathy. He saw her and knew her in a way she wasn't ready for. And what did she know about *him* ? The only things that came to mind were his wife, who she had helped send to her doom, and Glimmer—and Micah had already said on the morning they spoke after the briefing, that Catra was only important to him because she was important to Glimmer.

The king, for his part, looked just as worried as either of them. Neither Glimmer nor Catra had any idea how this next part was supposed to go. They were pretty sure Micah didn't either—until he cleared his throat and looked both of them in the eyes.

"I know none of us really knows what to do, so—being the elder here—I guess I'll start." He held a hand out to Catra and Glimmer each, and they exchanged a glance before taking them. They gingerly bridged the distance between themselves as well, Glimmer's fingers curling gently in the palm of Catra's hand.

"Glimmer," Micah started, then paused for a deep breath. She looked into his eyes and couldn't help but see herself in their shape, in the width of his nose and the curve of his chin. "Maybe you knew this already, but … when I was on Beast Island, I didn't know how long it had been. The last time I saw you before that, you were barely old enough to read. I thought I would get to be there for your big moments—your connection to the Moonstone, your first spell, your first ball, everything. I held onto that hope during my exile as best I could, but…"

His eyes closed flinchingly, and Glimmer noticed tears on his eyelashes. His voice trembled when he spoke again:

"I can't deny, there were times when I wished I had died on that battlefield. Knowing the grief that Angie must have felt, knowing

you were growing up without me, it was too much to bear sometimes. But I held onto that idea of being back with you and your mother again, and that's the only reason I made it out—even when I found out that she was…" Catra grimaced, and Micah's eyes flicked toward her apologetically. "Even when I found out that she was gone and you were queen, just knowing I would be home with you, where I was always meant to be, that was enough."

Glimmer choked on tears. "Dad…"

He continued, unabated, "Since we've been reunited, I've been trying to be the father you never had, to make up for all that lost time. But the way I just can't seem to get to you, it's made me feel like maybe … maybe the damage is done. I lost those years and there's no getting them back. And without Angella to bridge the gap, it's just…"

The next words were Catra's. Her hands shook under the weight. "I'm sorry, Your Majesty. Micah."

"It's okay, Catra," Micah said, smiling softly. "It's not your fault. You're just a kid."

"I'm twenty-two," she said tearily—half retort, half self-indictment.

Micah chuckled. "You're still a kid. Trust me." He took his hand away, wiped his tears, then gave it back. "Catra, this is why I was trying to get through to you. To form some kind of bond. I just feel so alone, so desperate for that connection, and … and I recognize the ways you've been hurt. I still haven't healed from them either. I just wondered if we could heal together, all of us. If maybe then I would finally be strong enough."

"It's not your fault, Dad," said Glimmer. The dam broke, finally. "I'm … I know you're here. And I know you love me, I just … I don't know you, but at the same time, I do. I know the parts of you that became *me.* It's hard to love those parts of myself, but when they're *you* … And then what if I get to know the rest of

you, and love those parts too, but then I lose it all again?" The tears streamed down her face, but she kept on with queenly composure. "It's not your fault. I'm just so scared of losing the people I love that it feels safer not to love anyone new."

Micah's face fell at the word *new.* He sighed. "I *am* new, aren't I? I can't be the father you never had. Those years are gone." Glimmer opened her mouth to interrupt him, to take back the truth, but Micah's tone changed and he looked back at her. "But I can be the father you need now. Nothing, nobody can stop me."

His face hardened. "Shadow Weaver … she took everything from me before. She abused me, manipulated me, nearly killed me before I turned sixteen, and then left me behind. And then she came back later and took everything again. When I thought I'd finally escaped her, I came back from Beast Island to find her there in place of my daughter. I'm not going to let her take anything else from me, ever again. Not my magic," he paused to squeeze Catra's and Glimmer's hands twice, "and not you two."

Glimmer sniffled. "Dad … I love you."

"I love you too, babygirl."

"I just…" she trailed off, barely letting the words form in her head before they flowed out of her, fuel into the fire. "I was so used to you being gone, that it was … well, it was a fact of life. It was history, it was a mural in Bright Moon and a statue in Mystacor. For all intents and purposes, you were dead. But you came back. I had no idea how to deal with that, plus Prime and the war and then the reconstruction… I know I'm supposed to be close to you —you're my dad," she said with a quiet smile, and squeezed his hand back. "I just couldn't imagine how, until now."

Glimmer looked to Catra, and Catra blushed under the sudden attention. "The first time I saw my dad's face since I was a baby, I was trapped on a starship in the heart of an alien empire, lightyears away from home. Before that, I was always thinking about the mission, trying to stay ahead of the game so nobody

could criticize me. It felt like the whole world was counting on me—still does, actually. I have to be this perfect queen or else someone will find a way to … use Mom's memory against me."

Catra parted her lips to speak, "Glimmer, I—"

"Hush," Glimmer said with a chuckle. "I'm not done yet. Catra, you were the first friend I made after the biggest mistake of my life. I thought it would hurt to talk to you after everything you did, knowing you were the one who pulled the lever, but … I just didn't have the energy to blame you for it anymore. I had learned what it felt like to run out of options and do something terrible, only to realize it was wrong. And there was so much else that had happened that neither of us had any control over. I was still grieving then, just like I am now. But it's not in spite of you.

"In fact," she continued, her tear-soaked smile falling to something sadder, "I kind of feel like you're one of the only people who understands my grief, Catra. After all, you came *that close* to losing the one you love, more than once. It could have been Adora in the portal, or Adora on Prime's ship, or Adora in the Heart. You know what it feels like to have someone one day and lose them the next. You're not stopping me from grieving my mom. For me, Catra, being your friend—loving you—it helps. You're good for me, Catra."

Catra shook as tears stung her eyes and spilled down her hot cheeks. She tasted them on her lips, salty like the dark ocean. Hoarsely, full of affection, she managed to say, "Fuck you for making me cry, Sparkles."

Glimmer chuckled. "Fuck you too, Horde Scum."

"I'm…" she started again, but choked on her words and a knot of nerves in her throat. "I'm so sorry, Glimmer. I'm so sorry."

"Catra, please, it's okay—"

Catra continued regardless of Glimmer's plea or her own inhibitions. "I just still feel all this … bullshit inside me, just rotting

garbage about everything I did during the war, about Angella and everything and… I convinced myself I was on borrowed time with you, both of you," she said, looking between Glimmer and Micah. "I felt like Adora forgiving me was my last little bit of good luck, and that I could never get there with you two. But I…" she closed her eyes and coughed, then laughed dryly. "Fuck. I can't believe myself."

Glimmer gave Catra a confused look, and Catra met it with eyes wide open, more earnest than the queen had ever seen her. "I love you, Glimmer. Not like, y'know, but… Yeah."

 Glimmer & Catra sit side by side, look at each other, and blush

"Aww, Catra!" Glimmer smiled giddily. "You're such a softie! I love you too."

"Shut up," Catra said affectionately. "Anyway… I used to think that Adora was the only person I'd ever love. Even after I made real friends for the first time, I was sure you would all leave me behind after a while. I thought it was always going to be me and Adora against the world, but … the world is so much softer than I realized. There are so many more people who—despite everything—care about me. And I want to care about them too. It's like … it's like everything I ever knew about myself was wrong."

Glimmer squeezed Catra's hand again. "Catra, that night in the garden, when I, uh…" she paused, blushed, looked quickly at Micah and then back at Catra, "when I kissed you—"

"You what?!"

"—it was because I was trying to show you that you were wrong. I was trying to shut your big damn mouth. I couldn't let you talk about yourself that way."

A smile turned up the corners of Catra's mouth and softened her eyes. Glimmer blushed even hotter, somehow, as she said, "I mean, sure, I was a little … worked up, but more than anything I just wanted you to stay."

"I get it, Sparkles," Catra said softly. "I would have made out with myself too."

"Gods, you're so annoying."

Catra let out one of her scratchy, squeaky laughs, then continued, "But seriously, Glimmer … and Micah," she said, meeting the king's half-slack-jawed stare, "I want to stay with you guys, if you'll have me. I want Adora and all of her embarrassing friends—and their dads—too."

"I'm not just your friend's dad, Catra," said Micah. "I'm sorry if I made it sound that way."

Catra froze, her heart stopping at the unexpected warmth.

"I'm your friend, too. I know some of the things you've been through, and you remind me of myself in a lot of ways—the best ways. And if you want, you'll always have a friend and a … *guardian* in me."

A single tear traced a stream down Catra's cheek. She was without words. That feeling of profound safety wrapped around her again, securing the place where her hand rested in Micah's. It filled an empty spot somewhere inside her, like finally finding the missing cornerstone of a house that was once meant to protect her—broken, still, but she could see how to mend it now.

As Glimmer watched this, where some younger version of her might have been jealous to see her father extending his care to someone else, she only felt warm. It permeated everything, filled the room, and suddenly it didn't feel like a guest room in Mystacor anymore. It felt like a home. She was powerless to stop the overflowing joy, and swept Catra and Micah into a hug. They both grunted in surprise, but each wrapped an arm around her—Catra's lean, delicate arm around her waist, hand on her hip, and her father's comforting strength around her shoulder. All three sighed a relieved breath into each other, the last of the tension draining out like the dregs at the bottom of a teapot.

Then, a knock on the door. Catra and Glimmer both froze up, but Micah held them tight around the shoulders, unashamed, as he called out, “Come in!”

The doors flung open again, and Mortella was there, dark robes wrinkled and bunched up, arms folded and full of jars, more old books, and what looked like some kind of rolled-up tapestry. She blew into the room like a gust of wind. Behind her, to Glimmer’s surprise, was Castaspella, similarly toting a hodgepodge of supplies, scrolls, and crystals. She looked … disgruntled, to say the least, probably owing to the fact that she was playing second fiddle to her ex-girlfriend. But all traces of frustration vanished when she saw Micah with his arms around Glimmer and Catra.

“Oh, Micah!” said Castaspella, trying very hard to sound genuine. “Don’t you three look happy. How wonderful.”

Mortella hummed as she set her mound of supplies down on the floor. “How do you feel? If you’re sufficiently open to each other, we can start setting up the ritual.”

Catra and Glimmer both blushed and looked away, finding each other’s eyes from either side of Micah. But Micah himself didn’t look the slightest bit embarrassed.

“I think we’re ready, yes,” said the king confidently. “What do we need to do?”

“Well,” Mortella started as she organized her materials, “I have gathered here a wide variety of herbs and oils which counteract negative energy, some salt for protection, crystals for focusing, a pre-drawn spell circle… I just need you three to help set all of this up.”

Glimmer shrugged off her father’s arm and chimed in, with sudden fervor, “That sounds good. Let’s do this.”

Mortella held out a hand to the young queen. “Ah, one more thing. We’ll need some physical connection to the spirit,

something she touched frequently or a room she spent a lot of time in, that sort of thing."

"Will this work?" Glimmer said, and retrieved the Light Spinner book from the bed stand. Mortella turned it over in her hand, humming thoughtfully.

"No," she said, "it's not a direct enough connection. If you had the original manuscript maybe, but this is, what … second edition? No, we need something that was personal to her."

Glimmer sighed. She turned back to her father, whose face was taut with concentration. He opened his mouth to speak, but then —

"Aha!" Castaspella exclaimed. "That room I was going to give you, Micah—the one with the mold problem—I'm fairly sure that used to be Shadow Weaver's personal quarters. Could that—"

"Excellent, Casta," Mortella said cheekily. "Maybe you're not such a wet blanket after all, hm?" She playfully tilted Casta's chin up with one finger, which caused the head sorceress' cheeks to burn bright pink.

Mortella clapped her hands together and examined the three of them—Micah, then Glimmer, then Catra—for a long moment. Then, "Let's be off to the old witch's chamber, shall we? We shouldn't keep her waiting. Spirits can be awfully impatient." She gathered her supplies again. Castaspella sighed, then gathered her portion as well and followed Mortella to the door.

Micah followed next, Glimmer and Catra falling behind him, somewhat nervously. Before they left the room, Mortella waved a hand and sigils flashed navy blue on all the windows and doors, then dissipated into mist.

"Let's hope we don't need those anymore."

Chapter End Notes

GET HYPED FOR THE BIG MAGIC THING

illustration by EmileeDoodles

hold you under 'til you still; or, the ritual

Night air blew through the corridors of Mystacor, colder than Catra could bear. She shivered, her skin twitching under her clothes, and the feeling brought an awful memory to the surface: the last time she had come to Mystacor, during the war. The night that Shadow Weaver had forced Adora to take the Failsafe, to deny her own life for the sake of everyone else's. The dark sorceress had touched Catra that night, wrapped a hand over her mouth and an arm around her waist, and it had burned like ice—still did, sometimes, if she let herself remember it. She wondered if that was a trace of her magic, or just a trick of memory.

Glimmer watched Catra as she recalled that night and decided, now that there were no more barriers keeping them apart, to reach out and lay a hand on Catra's arm. Where she touched, Catra's skin was cold and clammy. Catra jumped slightly, but then noticed Glimmer and relaxed, a safe, grateful expression washing over her face.

"Thanks, Sparkles," she muttered. "I'm just … remembering." On her arm, Glimmer's hand was warm like a patch of sun-bathed ground.

"I figured," said Glimmer with a soft smile. "You don't have to remember alone."

When they reached the door of the darkened room, Catra could already see the shadows flickering under the door. They seemed not to bother Castaspella as she fished a key from her robes, slid it into the lock, and traced a cerulean rune around it. The lock clicked, the door opened, and the shadows receded into the room. As Castaspella entered, Mortella cast a glance back to Micah, Glimmer, and Catra before following.

Micah reached his hands back to Catra and Glimmer on either side of him. Without a second thought, each gave him her hand in return, and they strode into the room side-by-side.

The room, when Castaspella flicked the lights on, did not strike Glimmer as being particularly unique from any other room in Mystacor. There was no furniture or decoration on the walls, but there wasn't anything sinister either—at least, not at first. But eventually, Glimmer's gaze landed on the far wall, where she saw the so-called *mold problem* that had made the room unavailable in the first place: a dark stain as tall as the ceiling, a monument-sized silhouette. Terror gripped Glimmer's bones.

"That's … horrible," said Micah quietly. "I think that's the wall this room shares with the Hall of Sorcerers. It must be right behind her statue."

A gasp escaped Catra's throat. Despite still holding hands with Micah, she trembled under the feeling of being openly watched, like a caged animal.

"It's certainly something," Mortella said, with not a little bit of wonder. "I've never heard of a shadow spirit doing *that* before. She must have put an enchantment on the statue. Something incredibly powerful—blood magic maybe?"

"Ugh. Disgusting," Castaspella whispered.

"Maybe so," said the occultist as she began rolling out a tapestry on the floor, "but lucky for us, blood magic means she left *blood.* She had to leave a physical part of herself here, which makes it much easier to banish her." She flattened the tapestry, revealing a large, complex spell circle painted on it: points indicating the cardinal directions, sigils that represented the twelve moons and the elements, and several smaller outlying circles. Mortella pointed to one and instructed Micah to sit, then indicated two others for Glimmer and Catra to take their places.

They did, but not without hesitation. Neither was particularly keen on letting go of the other; the very air in the room sizzled with hostility and although the shadows in the corners weren't making any moves, it still felt safer for Catra and Glimmer to ground themselves in each other. But after a moment, both sat cross-

legged on the tapestry, forming a triangle with Micah around the edge of the spell circle.

Mortella placed several glass jars between them, each filled with an herb or powder of some kind, and an ancient-looking, shallow, metal bowl with a hunk of clear crystal in the center of the circle. Then, she got down on all fours, ruffling and dirtying her robes, and poured salt from a bottle in a larger circle around all of them in the room.

"We're going to start with a pretty serious invocation," said Mortella as she lifted herself off the floor finally. She produced two bundles of sticks and two vials of water from somewhere in her cloak and handed one pair to Castaspella, who then dutifully stood on the opposite side of the circle from her.

She waved a hand, glowing with magic, and suddenly Glimmer, Micah, and Catra were holding identical sheets of parchment—exactly identical, down to the fraying on the edges. "You three," Mortella instructed, "read that out loud together, and Casta and I will cleanse."

The would-be casters shared a nervous glance, then began reading in unison from the parchment:

"Magic of Etheria, hear our call,
Mother of the gods and angels all,
Moons and seasons, elements and powers,
Blooming as the mightiest of flowers:
Lend us your protection and your favor,
And we shall be indebted to you ever.
Goddess, may your Guardian's sword strike true
And her shield deflect all malice against you."

The parchment vanished just as quickly as it had materialized, and Glimmer helpfully pointed out, "Okay, *favor* does not rhyme with *ever."*

“It’s a slant rhyme, Your Highness,” Mortella said as she capped her now-empty vial and extinguished her smoking herbs. “Translating poetry from a dead language is not as easy as it—”

Before she finished speaking, the room ignited with a flash of golden light. Catra could barely open her eyes for a moment, but when the glow died down, it revealed the source of the luminescence: the circle of salt on the floor. The sight of it flooded Catra’s nerves with a buzz that she couldn’t quite comprehend. It almost reminded her of She-Ra, except purer somehow, undiluted.

“What … what is that?” she asked in a whisper.

“That,” Mortella said reverently, “is the oldest magic in the world.”

But past the incandescent glow of the circle, in the corners of the rooms where night still reached, Catra watched the shadows slithering together again. They moved along the molding of the ceiling and converged on the giant silhouette, wreathing it in dark tendrils. Catra could only point to it in horrified silence.

“Fascinating,” whispered Mortella. “She’s gathering herself up. Don’t worry, though, she shouldn’t be able to reach us inside the salt circle. We should begin the ritual right away.” She waved her hand again, and three more sheets of parchment appeared in front of Catra, Micah, and Glimmer, these ones much larger and more dense with words than the first.

They were instructions for the spell, Glimmer figured. As she read the ingredients, they all appeared to be common herbs, spices, minerals—until she reached the final ingredient: tea leaves. The rest of the ingredients, too, lent themselves to a strange but not-unappetizing blend. She couldn’t help but laugh a little as she reached for a pinch of the first component.

With tense determination, Glimmer, Catra, and Micah set about dropping ingredients into the bowl and reciting their purposes, according to the ritual instructions. Each addition caused another color to refract through the prismatic crystal in the center until

they all shone like a rainbow, contrasting the menacing shadows massing on the walls.

Catra reached for the final component, a pitcher of purified water, and had just begun to pour its contents into the bowl—when her ear twitched from a hissing whisper behind her:

"You'll have to do better than that, I'm afraid."

She dropped the pitcher and the remaining contents spilled across the tapestry, darkening the fabric like blood. Glimmer and Micah gasped, but before either could ask what was happening, a harsh and unnatural wind swept into the room through the open windows, blowing the curtains almost sideways.

"What's happening?" shouted Glimmer, and almost at the same time her father answered, "She's fighting back!"

Mortella and Castaspella exchanged a panicked glance, neither really looking they knew what to do. The light from the ring of salt dimmed like a candle being starved of oxygen, and then was suddenly snuffed out when a supernatural gust cut through the circle, blowing the salt away like desert sand.

That was when the cold returned to Catra. Hands of frost wrapped around her, though she couldn't see them, suffocating her nervous system like a lead blanket. Her claws came out and dug into icy nothingness, and it bled all over her hands. Catra screamed—a blood-curdling, desperate sound.

"You three will never truly be rid of me," the wind declared in Shadow Weaver's voice. *"Even if you manage to see this ritual through to the end, you'll always remember me. And as long as you remember me, my power over you will persist."*

Glimmer felt the cold too, but not in her veins like Catra did; Glimmer felt it in her heart. She wondered if it was true, what the wind said. Would she always be chained to the memory of Shadow Weaver, bound to her with shadows and red lightning like she was before? Memories are powerful, it's true, but do they rule

a person? They can, certainly, but what gives them that power? Angella's memory still weighed on Glimmer, but she was not beholden to her mother; Glimmer carried her as a part of herself. Angella only went where Glimmer and Micah went. She lived on through them, but they did not live for her sake.

Her memories were powerful, Glimmer thought, but only so long as she gave them power. And with Catra and Micah, their three strong wills together, no memory could control them. Glimmer chose the good memories, the friends and family and love that she had, past and present. Those were the ones she would give power to today.

The Queen of Bright Moon stood against the howling wind, raised her hands, and drew a line—a circle, then another, then a square and a star, and a host of runes and sigils. Magic surged forth from her hands like water rushing from a broken dam and blazed magenta in the middle of the room. Then, with a final push of intent, a wave of force crashed outward to where the salt circle once glowed, and a solid wall of pink fire took its place.

The shadow spirit released its hold on Catra once again, and she doubled over her knees, palms flat on the wetted canvas of the tapestry. She breathed a sigh that didn't quite reach the bottoms of her lungs. By the grace of her friend, she was safe—for now.

"Glimmer," Micah said breathily, "how did you do that?"

Glimmer thought for a moment, then, "Instead of thinking about what I wanted to do, I thought about you guys. And about Mom. Who I wanted to protect, who I wanted to remember, and why."

Her father's face softened with a gentle realization. A tear formed in his eye, to match the ones in Glimmer's.

"That was an incredible display, Your Majesty," Mortella said, awed, "and I'm humbled to have witnessed it. But you must finish the ritual if you want to banish the spirit." She glanced at Castaspella, and both of them suddenly looked empowered,

transformed into the powerful magicians they were supposed to be, despite their differences and their juvenile grudges and their robes all askew.

Castaspella reached her hand out to Mortella, and Mortella took it eagerly. Without looking away, she said, "Mortella and I will hold the protection spell together. Finish the ritual."

Catra stared at her hands on the floor, still wet. "I spilled the rest of the water," she grumbled. "Is there a way around that?"

She hadn't expected an answer, figuring that she, like always, had ruined their chances. But to her surprise, Micah provided one: he shut his eyes, breathed deep, and hovered his hand over the wet spot with one finger extended. Another pink circle sprung to life at his fingertip, and the glow extended to the floor, appearing to literally reverse the spill: the pitcher righted itself, and the water extracted itself from the tapestry and settled back in its container as if nothing had happened.

"Okay, well," Catra said, still not entirely comprehending what she had just seen, "that's … cool. I guess I'll just…"

Micah released the spell and opened his eyes—Glimmer saw him get a subtle fist pump in before returning to his composure—just as Catra reached for the pitcher to pour the remainder of its contents into the spell bowl. Just as before, something tried to interrupt her, but this time it was nothing more than a sharp sound like knocking on a sheet of ice. She heard Castaspella and Mortella grunt with effort in response, but there was nothing further as the last of the water spilled out of the pitcher and into the slurry of ingredients in the bowl.

The final component of the spell was scrawled at the bottom of the parchment with barely enough room to spare: two lines of incantation, to be recited by the casters while holding hands. Cautiously, Catra, Glimmer, and Micah took each other's hands once more and began:

"Now with this spell of cleansing we do cast—"

But before they could say the next line, more percussive sounds erupted from the wall of Glimmer's magic. Mortella and Castaspella gripped each other with white knuckles and hands raised in resistance to the siege. One wavered, then the other, and then there were splotches of darkness bleeding through the magenta light of the protection spell. Limbs of shadow inched their way past the barrier, little by little, reaching for all of them.

"Finish the spell!" Castaspella ordered, then ripped her hand from Mortella's and traced another circle in the air, this one neon blue and flickering. Incandescent magical bindings froze the shadows where they lay.

Glimmer looked at her father, at her friend, and nodded them on.

"Let spirits rest as memories in the past."

In an instant, the protection spells failed and darkness came rushing toward the center of the room, surrounding Catra in an inescapable cold that went directly to her bones—but just as quickly, the crystal in the spell bowl came to life with radiant energy. At first it glowed red, like a coal, but it quickly burned brighter and brighter, orange, yellow, blue, then violent white. Flames—real ones, flames that melted the cold in Catra's bones—shot upwards in a pillar, then fanned out on the ceiling until every corner of the room was bathed in fire.

In the roar of magic, Catra heard one more whisper—or was it a memory?

"You're welcome."

She decided not to think about it.

don't let anybody call them ugly; or, the blessing

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

The smell of sulfur was the most powerful force in the room as Catra, Glimmer, and Micah assisted Mortella and Castaspella with tidying up after their cleansing spell. The shadows were gone, the stains on the wall, and the cold too. All that was left was what was between them—a comfortable, relieved silence, and a bowl of magically brewed tea. Once the tapestry was folded and the materials gathered up, Micah put his arms around Glimmer and Catra, and they eagerly returned his embrace.

A cup of cleansing tea in each of their hands, the queen, her father, and her friend returned to the guest rooms. Standing outside the room with two beds—the one Glimmer and Micah were intended to share—they paused and looked at each other.

"I…" Catra started, plumbing the depths of her vulnerability for something to say, "I don't really think I want to sleep alone after that."

Glimmer breathed a chuckle, and smiled at Catra. "Me neither. Dad," she said, and Micah's face lit up when she called him that, "can we all share this room tonight?"

"Of course, babygirl," said Micah quietly. He pushed the doors open and the two of them followed him in, treading softly, leaving Mortella and Castaspella to whatever business they had.

Glimmer immediately settled on one of the beds, setting her tea down and picking up her mini-pad—until Catra's hand pushed it back down.

“Come on, princess,” she said, sitting down next to Glimmer with her tea, “let yourself breathe. You just, like, banished a dark spirit.”

“Yeah,” Glimmer sighed, “I guess I did. But so did you.” She smiled, picked her tea back up, and leaned her head on Catra’s shoulder. Quietly, Catra began to purr.

“This tea is surprisingly good,” Micah said after a sip, sitting across from them on his bed. “For a tea we brewed in a spell bowl with magic fire, I mean. Or does that make it better?”

Catra shrugged, jostling Glimmer’s head. “I really don’t know that much about tea. Or, uh, magic.” She blushed as she voiced the strange shame she felt about it—her lack of magical ability still felt like an aberration sometimes.

“Well you can sense it, can’t you?” said Micah. Glimmer lifted her head and looked at Catra questioningly. Could she?

“Uh,” said Catra, stumbling, “a—a little? I have the weird empathic link thing with Melog, and then…”

“Sorry,” said Micah with his hand held up, “I didn’t mean to pry. It’s just, I think I heard a legend a long time ago about—”

Whatever he had been about to say, it got lost as Glimmer’s mini-pad buzzed with an urgent message. In the same instant, Catra’s spine tingled with fear out of thin air; not hers, but Melog’s. “Something is happening,” she said quietly, choked with empathic panic.

The message on Glimmer’s mini-pad confirmed the same: a single text from Bow, saying, *You’re gonna want to get back to Bright Moon. There’s something in Adora’s room.*

Glimmer stopped breathing. Without another word, she stood up, grabbed Catra’s shoulder and Micah’s hand, and overflowed with the light of the Moonstone to hurry them homeward.

In a flash of slightly nauseating light, Catra, Glimmer, and Micah reappeared in the main corridor of Castle Bright Moon, just down the hall from Adora's suite. Despite the turning of her stomach, Catra immediately took off down the hall, pulled along by a terrible thread tied directly to her heart. It was beating, beating, beating, so hard and so fast that it almost burst from Catra's chest and made it to the bedroom before the rest of her.

Glimmer followed behind as fast as she could, and Micah behind her. When they reached the door to the bedroom, Bow and Melog were pressing against it with the weight of their bodies, to no avail. Catra joined them at first, but something pushed her away violently, her tail and ears shooting straight back as if she had been shocked.

Under the door, shadows flickered like flames.

"Adora!" Catra shouted, her fist against the door once again, ignoring the shock of cold in her bones. "Adora, are you there?"

Only faintly, as if muffled behind too many layers of glass, Catra heard Adora call her name. She breathed a sigh of momentary relief, then, "Adora, we're coming. I'm not going to let anything happen to you. We're getting in there."

Bow grunted as he gave up pushing on the door. "I've been trying to open it for I don't even know how long. It's not even locked, it just won't budge. Like it's … frozen or something."

It is frozen, Melog chirped into Catra's mind. *You felt the cold yourself, Catra.*

"It's frozen," Catra said, thinking, "so … let's melt it."

"What?" Glimmer and Micah said in unison.

"If this is the same … *stuff* that was fucking with us in Mystacor, then maybe some fire will do the trick," she explained quickly. "Magic fire, I mean."

“Oh,” said Micah. Glimmer examined him, cocking an eyebrow. “Well, that’s my specialty,” he said with a little pride.

Everyone stepped aside as Micah squared himself in front of the door, the shadows creeping further and further outward, almost reaching his feet. He closed his eyes, took a deep breath, and slowly traced a wide circle in the air in front of him. Vibrant red light followed his fingers, humming and sparking like a tamed firecracker. When the circle was complete, a single rune ignited within it like gunpowder, and a torrent of pure red flames rushed out.

Glimmer and Catra flinched and squinted, both at the pyrotechnics and at the strangled hissing noise it made when it collided with the magically sealed door. It took a few seconds, but Micah’s fire won out, blasting the door nearly off its hinges and into the room. When the magic cleared, the room within was ink-dark, shadows slithering nearly everywhere. Another infernal whisper crossed Catra’s ear:

“Tsk, tsk. Don’t try to take this from me too. Do you know how hard I worked to mold you children?”

“Rot in hell, you moldy bitch,” growled Catra, and she plunged into the room.

The familiar features of the suite she and Adora shared were all drenched in unnatural darkness, cold and twisted, and she had to physically restrain her reflexes against the way the shadowy tendrils felt as they slipped off her skin, unable to take hold again. At the center of the room under the purple canopy, a curled-up figure quivered under the sheets. Adora looked so small, so helpless surrounded by Shadow Weaver’s undying spirits, that it made Catra wish she could have killed the old witch with her bare hands. She would take the next best thing, whatever that ended up being.

“Adora,” Catra whispered, her hands coming to the edge of the sheet gently, “Adora it’s okay. I’m here. We’re gonna make this go

away, okay?”

When Catra saw Adora’s face, her heart nearly tore itself in half. Adora’s dark eyebrows were pushed all the way together, eyes squeezed shut as tight as they would go, her lips drawn open and teeth clenched against the torture. One stormy eye cracked open, and Adora sobbed when she saw Catra.

“Please,” she said, strained, “I don’t know what’s happening, I thought she was gone, I thought I was—safe.”

“You are safe, okay? I’m not gonna let her hurt you. Never, ever again.”

Glimmer and Micah rushed in after Catra, with Bow and Melog following behind. Immediately, they were hand in hand, casting a protection spell around the bed on sheer instinct. It only barely kept the shadows at bay.

“What is this?” said Bow, his voice shaking, and Catra leaned up from Adora’s trembling form to answer, “It’s Shadow Weaver. Or, what’s left of her. This was happening to us in Mystacor.”

“I don’t know how we’re going to cast that spell again,” Micah said. He stroked his beard as he thought out loud. “We don’t have any of the ingredients, and we don’t have any physical traces of her here.”

Glimmer picked up the thought. “Well,” she started slowly, “there is a version we can cast using conjuration, right? Do we just need to, like … replace all the ingredients with runes and symbols that represent them?”

“Generally, that would work, yeah,” Micah mused, and then flinched as an awful scratching noise penetrated the barrier for a moment before subsiding. “But that doesn’t account for the connection to the target. We have—”

“Wait,” Bow interrupted. He had his planning face on, and Glimmer’s heart lit up to see him work his own type of magic.

"You said that ingredients can be replaced by symbols. Why can't the connection to the target be symbolic, too?"

Micah lifted a finger and opened his mouth, as if to correct Bow, but then said simply, "Huh. What are you thinking?"

Bow smiled a broad smile—despite the horror of the situation, despite everything, he was still as bright as daylight—and explained, "Well, if it's something that had a lot to do with Shadow Weaver, why can't it be Catra and Adora's relationship?"

"Wait, what?" said Catra, protectively grasping Adora's shoulder. Adora herself was wide-eyed and red-faced, part-terrified, part-embarrassed, part-confused.

"I just mean, she tried to keep you guys apart, right? She tried to put you on these strict paths and stuff."

"Yeah," Adora said quietly, under the dull roar of shadowy wind. "It was like her life's greatest ambition."

"Your rivalry," Glimmer said, beginning to understand. "She *made* your rivalry!"

"But how do you burn a rivalry?" asked Micah.

Bow simply gestured towards Catra and Adora with both hands, as if presenting his most elegant invention yet.

"Oh," said Adora. *"Ohh."*

In minutes, a spell circle was traced on the ground, filled with arcane sigils and runes to represent the various aromatic ingredients of the cleansing tea spell. Glimmer felt quite proud of herself for it, really—she had never thought she would excel at sorcery like her father, but maybe Shadow Weaver had been right about this one thing.

Catra and Adora knelt in the middle of the circle, both hands clasped with each other's. Adora was shaking still, but with Catra there the fear seemed to be less visceral. Adora stared into Catra's eyes and she stared back, partly in an attempt to not look at anything around them, and partly for the same reason she always had: Adora's eyes were as blue as a clear sky, and if Catra stared long enough she swore she could fly away, leave everything behind except for her, a world that began and ended with Adora.

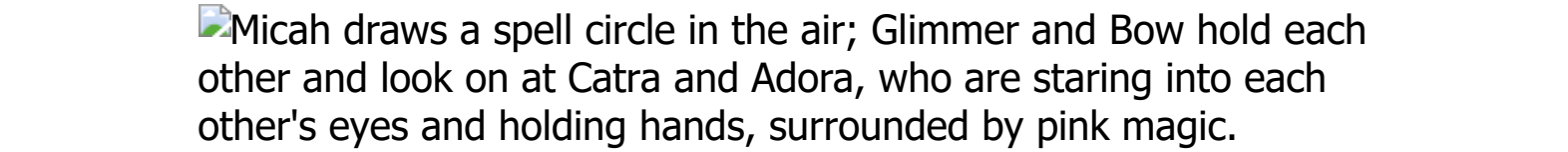
Micah whispered an incantation for the two of them to say, then took the fabric belt from his tunic and wrapped it around their hands, tying them together that they might never let go again. In spite of the sound and fury surrounding them, Catra let herself smile at Adora, and Adora smiled in return. There wasn't a doubt in Catra's mind that this would work.

"Alright," said Micah as he tugged the band of fabric tight, "I think that should do it." He stepped away and relieved Glimmer of her duty maintaining the protection spell.

Glimmer and Bow looked on, holding hands as Catra and Adora recited the apparently improvised words that Micah had given them:

"Now we are as we have been, and always hence shall be: what's mine is yours and yours is mine, spirits, hearts, and home…"

At once, the spell circle began to glow, the terrible scratching and pounding from outside the protection field started up again, and Micah grunted with effort, drawing several more spell circles in the air to strengthen it. Catra and Adora paused at the rush of activity, but Micah commanded, "Keep going!"


Micah draws a spell circle in the air; Glimmer and Bow hold each other and look on at Catra and Adora, who are staring into each other's eyes and holding hands, surrounded by pink magic.

Their eyes fixed on each other again, and they continued:

"And when we die, let death be home as well for you and me. Goddess bless us, moons shine on—we'll never be alone."

Catra wasn't sure what moved her to kiss Adora in that moment—maybe it was the same string around her heart that had always tugged her towards Adora, or maybe it was just the way Adora's lips looked as she said those words—but she did, without a second thought. Their mouths slotted together, the warmth between their lips mingling like tea diffusing its essence into water. Adora sunk into it easily, and maybe, just for this moment, that was the whole world. Maybe there was truly nothing else that mattered.

The sound of a wind so strong that it was almost a scream pierced the room. Catra and Adora broke apart, though their hands still held one another fiercely. Glimmer watched the spell circle on the floor with all its sigils and runes glowing, definitely ready to blow, but still not releasing its cleansing power like it had in Mystacor.

"Dad," Glimmer shouted over the noise, "it's not working! What did we miss?"

"Uhh— *ugh,"* said Micah, still struggling with the protection spell. He thought out loud again, much louder this time. "We got the sigils for the ingredients, the symbolic connection to the target, the three— *wait!"* He looked at Glimmer with panic. "The spell needs *three* people with a connection to the target, we only have two!"

"Can the third one be me?" asked Glimmer, and she wasn't sure what she meant by that. Micah looked at her like she had just suggested they all stop and eat a bowl of noodles.

"I guess— *ugh*— but Glimmer, the ceremony we just performed with them—"

"Bow," Glimmer said, urgently turning to her boyfriend as she started to figure out exactly what she meant, "remember what

you said about kissing other people?"

"What?!"

"Well, I'm asking," she said impatiently, but still as gently as she could. "The spell needs three people to work, and I'm number three."

Bow stared at her slack-jawed. "How do you know that'll work? Since when did kissing become a part of casting spells?"

For that, she kissed him. He tensed up at first, then melted into her as she sent a pulse of magical intention through her tongue. When she pulled away, there was no more doubt in his eyes.

"Okay," Bow said, "yeah. Okay. It's magic."

She smiled at him. "I love you."

"I love you, too. Now go kiss our friends."

Eagerly, Glimmer knelt down next to Catra and Adora in the middle of the spell circle. "Guys," she said slowly, "I need to kiss you. Both of you."

Adora's face turned bright red instantly, and Catra's a deep, warm brown.

"For the spell," Glimmer explained quickly. Her traitorous cheeks flooded with heat. "It's uh … not because I…" She sighed, and gave up. "Okay, yes, you're both really hot and I have thought about doing this before but this is for magic reasons *only.* Promise."

Catra looked at Adora, and Adora at Catra. This development struck Catra as … less surprising than it should have been, though still unexpected. But in the state of shock and terror the night had left her in, she was prepared to do just about anything to finally be free of Shadow Weaver. And kissing Glimmer again—and seeing Adora kiss Glimmer—was definitely less shitty than some

alternatives she could think of. Marginally less shitty. She hoped this sentiment was shared by Adora, who was staring at her just as dumbfounded as ever. Catra shrugged, *Sure, why not,* and Adora nodded, slowly at first, then more confidently.

Glimmer wasted absolutely no time in taking Catra's face between her hands and pressing their lips together, and *oh wow, yeah,* it was *not* a friendly peck. Catra heard Adora gasp, and then herself as Glimmer's tongue slipped between her lips for just a second and it was *hot*—not just sensually but metaphysically also. Some kind of burn sparked through her nerves and set something on fire in the pit of her stomach, like dropping a hot coal onto a pile of tinder.

It burned Glimmer too, and she pulled away slowly from Catra's lips, her eyes lingering where her mouth had just been. Off behind her, she heard her father mutter, "I kind of feel like I shouldn't be here for this," and Bow replied, "I'm so sorry, Your Majesty." But Glimmer ignored both of them and moved over to Adora, who was practically glowing—wait, was she actually glowing? There was a thin halo of blue light around her blown-out pupils, and her skin looked even more radiant than usual.

Glimmer chuckled a little, then dove in and kissed Adora too—and oh, how she had wondered what this would feel like. It was different than she imagined, years ago when she'd first had her little crush. Adora's jaw was somehow even firmer than it looked, and her breath was warm and sweet against Glimmer's cheek. She had thought that Adora's kiss would be sharp, would cut her and expose her, but it was soft, soft, soft, all the way down to the core. Another jolt of heat ran through Glimmer's body and she pulled away just in time to avoid an embarrassing noise escaping her throat.

The spell circle burned a bright yellow, in contrast with the darkening pinks and browns painting Adora, Catra, and Glimmer's cheeks. All that was left was this: Glimmer put a hand on Catra and Adora's shoulders, and she didn't even have to push that hard—they were back on each other's lips in the blink of an eye. The

light from the circle turned white, approaching the fiery blue of Catra's left eye. Shadows whistled and hissed as they burned up trying to penetrate the barrier spell, but it was too late for them—as Catra and Adora locked lips, the queen held them together and said the words for them:

"With this spell of cleansing we do cast, let spirits rest as memories in the past."

No inky shadow could have survived the radiance that issued outward from the three of them then.

Chapter End Notes

illustration by EmileeDoodles

epilogue

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

On the eighth day of the second autumn since the end of the war, Queen Glimmer, her father King Micah, her boyfriend Bow, and her friends Catra and Adora shared breakfast in the grand hall of Castle Bright Moon. It was late morning, the daymoons high in the sky casting their gentle heat over the palace like they had forgotten what season it was and showed up with their summer rays instead. Warm air blew in through the arches that lead out to the gardens. No cold spots hid in the corners; even the shadows were pleasantly temperate.

"You guys sleep okay?" Bow asked Catra and Adora, and they nodded, loose hair falling over each woman's forehead.

"Like a fucking rock," said Catra through a mouthful of steak and eggs. "Yesterday was maybe one of the longest days of my life."

Glimmer and Micah each groaned in agreement. "Aside from how long I was awake," Micah said, "I had never cast like that in my life before yesterday. It was powerful but, gods, it took a lot of energy."

"Yeah," Glimmer said with a chuckle, "like, emotional energy. Wow. And how did you come up with that incantation, dad? That was like … beautiful."

The king blushed bright red, maybe from embarrassment, but maybe also from his Bloody Mary. "Er, well … I didn't come up with it. It was something your mother taught me. She said it had been passed down through the royal family."

"Wow," whispered Adora. "An ancient, royal, angelic spell. No wonder it felt so powerful."

Micah chuckled awkwardly. “It, uh … wasn’t written as a spell, originally.” Glimmer stopped mid-bite and looked at her father. He stared down at his plate. Everyone else froze too, stopped by the weight of what Micah seemed to be saying.

“It was a marriage blessing. The same one Angie and I used when we got married.”

Catra’s fork clattered on the table. “Wait a second,” she whispered, “does that mean—”

“Was that a wedding?!” Adora shrieked. “Are we married?! I had a plan! We were gonna go to space and I was gonna give her my pin and stuff!”

“I’m sorry!” said Micah. He held his hands up in surrender. “It was a heat-of-the-moment decision on my part. I can annul it right away if you’d rather do it your way. It doesn’t have to mean anything.”

Catra cackled euphorically as Adora spiraled into a mini-meltdown. Eventually, she tamed her laughter enough to say, “Come on, dummy. If you were planning on, uh, proposing anyway,” she blushed as she stumbled on the words, still in a little bit of shock, “then why not? A wedding’s a wedding. Besides, now we can take a reeeeally long honeymoon.”

“Hold on,” said Glimmer, who had been snickering but now froze with her eyes wide in embarrassment, “that means I kissed a married couple. Oh my gods. Is that illegal? Am I going to get deposed?!”

Bow laughed warmly. “It’s not illegal, Glim. If it was, you could just decriminalize it by royal decree anyway.”

“Still. Ugh.” She cradled her face in her hands to hide a blush and a smile because, if she was being honest, she still didn’t regret it at all.

In fact, Glimmer realized, out of everything that had happened over the past week, the only thing she regretted was being so closed-off and not letting herself feel all of it sooner. The embarrassing kiss, the harrowing adventures in Mystacor's dark corners, the lesson she learned about magic—she would do it all again in a heartbeat, if it meant being this happy, this surrounded by love. Glimmer would steal the tea from the goddess herself if it meant she could share it with the people she cared about.

The grass in the garden was softer than ever that afternoon. There, Catra lay with her girlfriend—her *wife,* she corrected herself, and stared at the misty clouds as they passed in front of the sinking daymoons and revealed the stars in patches like hazy pools full of the night sky. She felt as if nothing could touch the life she had, no shadows or tyrants, no curses or destinies. All she needed was this woman: Adora with her wheat-gold hair and her sky-blue eyes and her heart like a star, ever-burning. Her wife, and her friends, and her friends' dads. All the love she could ever need, right here, under the moons and the arches of Castle Bright Moon.

"You really wanna go on a honeymoon?" Adora said quietly, a whisper in a bunk bed after lights out.

Catra looked at her and a smile spread across her face like a flame claiming a piece of dry grass. "Yeah," she replied, "I do."

Adora met her gaze and it was heart-stopping, just like always, the way her eyes shone in the light. "Where to?" she asked, and Catra had to work hard to remember what she meant.

Eventually, Catra managed a shrug and a grunt. "I dunno. Definitely not Mystacor. We could get a cabin in the woods or something."

"Maybe," said Adora distantly. She looked to the sky, searching for something. "Or maybe we could go out there."

Catra lifted herself up on an elbow and cocked an eyebrow at Adora. “To space?”

“Yeah,” said Adora. “I feel like it would be kind of nice, you know? No work, no She-Ra business, just … flying. Exploring. We could take Glimmer and Bow and finally have that road trip we talked about.”

An instinct whispered *danger* into Catra’s mind. *Unknown.* She tried to ignore it but found herself giving voice to it anyway. “Adora, we still don’t know what’s out there.”

Adora turned to her, her eyes soft and pleading, but understanding. “I know. But I want to find out. And if I’m going to find out, I want to do it with you.”

Catra laid herself back down and sighed. She still couldn’t push back against the part of her that wanted to hide where she knew it was safe. But maybe it wasn’t the *where* that mattered, as much as the *who.* And there was no one who made her feel safer than Adora. Adora and her still-new, precious *wanting.*

She smiled to herself and watched a star twinkle faintly behind the daylight. She found herself saying, “Sure, princess. But only if you promise not to get caught up in any more interstellar wars.”

From the corner of her eye, Catra saw her wife watching her, so she looked back, and she felt the word before Adora even finished saying it:

“Promise.”

Chapter End Notes

… 😉

End Notes

Thank you so much for reading! I had a great time writing this, and working with Emilee was an absolute pleasure. Go follow her everywhere. Also, here's the fic playlist again. I apologize for the type of person I am, but it's only on Apple Music.

If you're over 18, you can keep up with me on Twitter or Tumblr!

Please drop by the Archive and comment to let the creator know if you enjoyed their work!